Ep# 17 | WTF is Gaming in India? | Career, Investment, Entrepreneurship

[Speaker 1] (0:00 - 0:44)

So we just start rolling, okay? So how we typically start this is each one of us says something controversial about us that nobody knows right now. Ready guys?

So how we typically start this is each one of us says something controversial about us that nobody knows right now.

[Speaker 5] (0:45 - 0:48)

Hmm. I'm a listed company boss.

[Speaker 1] (0:48 - 0:49)

So what?

[Speaker 5] (0:50 - 0:51)

I'm part of a listed company.

[Speaker 4] (0:54 - 0:58)

You can talk about something not related to the company, more like personal. Yeah.

[Speaker 3] (1:00 - 1:06)

Okay. Shall I go? Yeah.

Well, I'm very temperamental, which people think I'm not.

[Speaker 1] (1:07 - 1:08)

You are temperamental?

[Speaker 3] (1:08 - 1:19)

Can be. Very explosive. 1% of the time.

I haven't really seen you. 0.1% of the time. My image is in the industry to be the most calmest person around.

[Speaker 1] (1:19 - 1:23)

Yeah. True. And who are you usually temperamental with?

[Speaker 3] (1:24 - 1:26)

Just very moody. Sometimes very moody.

[Speaker 1] (1:26 - 1:39)

Oh. So if I were to meet your childhood classmate, your best friend. Yeah.

And ask him, if Nitish is capable of one extremely naughty thing in life.

[Speaker 5] (1:39 - 1:39)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (1:39 - 1:44)

At the age of 40, 50, whatever. Yeah. What would he prophesize you be capable of doing?

[Speaker 3] (1:45 - 1:52)

You wouldn't believe it. Nothing. Come on.

I was the most simplest, most quietest kid in school.

[Speaker 5] (1:53 - 1:53)

Yeah?

[Speaker 3] (1:53 - 1:55)

Yeah. Absolutely. Very introvertish.

[Speaker 5] (1:55 - 1:56)

Yeah.

[Speaker 3] (1:57 - 1:58)

I've changed now.

[Speaker 1] (2:00 - 2:02)

Do you consider yourself an introvert today?

[Speaker 3] (2:03 - 2:11)

Yes, but much better than what I was when I was much younger. And I think YPO changed me a lot in the last decade or so.

[Speaker 1] (2:11 - 2:17)

Do you want to tell everybody who does not know what is YPO? Sure. Give us a minute on YPO.

[Speaker 3] (2:17 - 3:03)

YPO is the Young Presidents Organization. It's originally a US organization, but has more than 14, I think 15 or 16 chapters now in India. It brings together businessmen, professionals in a very close group.

Mumbai, for example, I think a total of 300 members might be there. And we organize a lot of learning events. Like I was just telling, right?

We're visiting Seoul next week. And we're doing a lot of learning activity. We're actually visiting Sean's large craft town office where we're meeting the CEO, etc.

I think it's a great networking event. And you may get to know a lot of great people. You're in YPO, so you can add to that what I didn't.

But yeah.

[Speaker 1] (3:05 - 4:32)

I think of YPO very differently. I have very first principles questioning about why people give so much money to an organization and then work for the organization for free. When I was not in YPO, I say bad things about everybody, okay?

This is a very open forum, so feel free to join me. And I'm going to pull all your legs, so feel free to pull it back. Otherwise, I'll feel bad and guilty at the end of it.

YPO, before I joined, appeared like this organization where rich people hang out. And I had a lot of curiosity about what rich people might be doing together when they hang out in a closed room. And they're not allowing cameras and outsiders to come in.

But in the few years that I have been with them, I have kind of realized that it's like a social network. It's a social network for people to hang out, eat, drink, chill, go on holidays. And also learn on the side.

So I don't know how to put YPO in a box, but it feels like if you move to a new city and you've been lucky in life, or you were born lucky in life, it's a good way to make friends very quickly.

[Speaker 3] (4:33 - 4:43)

That's true. And it's also brotherhood, right? So you go anywhere in the world and you meet a fellow YPO, there's instant connect.

Why is that? I think there's a code of conduct, right? YPO...

[Speaker 1] (4:43 - 4:47)

Forget all of that. Deep down, why is that? Trust, I think.

Why trust?

[Speaker 3] (4:47 - 4:50)

I think, one, because you are a YPO member.

[Speaker 1] (4:50 - 4:57)

Because you know, he is from Affluence and he has paid a certain amount of fee to be in our organization.

[Speaker 3] (4:58 - 5:16)

No, no, perhaps a little bit. But more importantly, I think it's also because as a YPO over the years, I've been a YPO over 10 years, right? I think you learn certain code of conducts, which you tend to stick to.

For example, confidentiality.

[Speaker 1] (5:17 - 5:19)

Do you want to introduce yourself professionally as well?

[Speaker 3] (5:19 - 5:59)

Yeah, sure. So I'm the founder and CEO of Nazara Technologies. Nazara is India's only listed gaming company.

I actually started coding games at the age of seven. So one of the lucky guys who discovered his passion at a very young age. And I've had the fortune of, at a young age, my parents encouraged me a lot.

I was doing gaming now, what, 37, 35 years back. And I pursued that for my entire life now. We became the first listed gaming company in 2021.

So three years now. And the journey continues, the game continues. I continue to play it.

[Speaker 1] (5:59 - 6:00)

Do you regret it, listing?

[Speaker 3] (6:01 - 6:02)

Not at all.

[Speaker 1] (6:02 - 6:02)

No?

[Speaker 3] (6:02 - 6:06)

I wouldn't have met you and got you as an investor.

[Speaker 1] (6:07 - 6:15)

Okay, for all the disclosures that should be made, I'm an investor in Nitesh's company. And what is it, 4-5%?

[Speaker 3] (6:16 - 6:16)

5%.

[Speaker 1] (6:16 - 6:55)

5% investor in Nitesh's company. And we meet often. And like I'm going to bug all of you today, I bug him a lot on questions.

Because I want to understand this domain a bit more. Today is rooted from that same curiosity. Because so many people are telling me that gaming is this next big thing.

The young today are spending so much more time on gaming than traditional forms of entertainment. So I have a lot of curiosity around it. But most people who have asked in person, not on camera, if they regret listing and becoming a public company, say they do.

[Speaker 3] (6:56 - 6:56)

I don't.

[Speaker 1] (6:57 - 6:57)

9 out of 10.

[Speaker 3] (6:58 - 6:59)

I absolutely don't.

[Speaker 1] (6:59 - 7:04)

But why do you inherently think listing a company is good? Is access to capital cheaper?

[Speaker 3] (7:05 - 7:31)

See, from our case, I think I really thought two things. Having done this business for a really long time, two decades, at a time when gaming didn't exist in India, I really felt at that point of time that one, by going public as India's first gaming company, we could really plant a flag that India is opening up. Is it good PR?

Very good PR. I mean, if things are going well.

[Speaker 1] (7:33 - 7:37)

Are any of your shareholders also your clients? Is there a significant overlap?

[Speaker 3] (7:38 - 7:54)

No. In terms of end players, there would be, but we don't market or cross market to them. I mean, we don't cross market our equity to our players.

It's difficult to extrapolate that or figure out the exact data, but there would be.

[Speaker 1] (7:54 - 8:04)

What is it? When you list a company, is it because you're able to get money cheaply and faster and easily? Is it that you're doing a marketing exercise?

[Speaker 5] (8:04 - 8:04)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (8:04 - 8:35)

I'm assuming when you go from pre-public to public, you spend as much as best case, one and a half, two percent, worst case, four, five percent in the bankers you bring in, the consultants you bring in, the accounting fees, all of that put together. So if somebody is spending that much money, what is the true incentive? If you're saying PR, your shareholders are not really your clients, if it's not capital, then what is it?

[Speaker 3] (8:35 - 8:45)

No, I think in the last three, four, five years, as Nazara went public, our brand visibility and company's credibility significantly increased.

[Speaker 1] (8:46 - 8:47)

Credibility to who?

[Speaker 3] (8:47 - 9:11)

To your customers? To a variety of stakeholders. I would say when I say customers, our customers are end gamers.

I think maybe not so much to them, but even partners like Sean and Krafton and global players like that, when they're coming into India and wanting to partner, I think today Nazara is clearly one company that they're very happy to talk to and partner. And maybe, Sean, you can agree or not agree with me.

[Speaker 4] (9:11 - 9:40)

Yeah, I mean, I totally agree. I mean, being listed gives a lot of good publicity, and then, like, feeling of trustworthiness to especially the companies outside India, which might not have a very good visibility and understanding about the backgrounds of the company. Actually, I felt the same when Krafton got listed, maybe around similar timing.

[Speaker 1] (9:42 - 9:45)

How big is Krafton? I know Nazara is 5,000 crores.

[Speaker 4] (9:47 - 9:51)

Our market cap is around 9 billion, 10 billion US dollar.

[Speaker 3] (9:52 - 10:25)

So that's one reason. I think there are many other related reasons as well. I also felt one of the reasons for a lot of private companies, like I was a VC-backed company for many, many years, and there are a lot of commitments, SHA terms, preferences that you give to the investors.

In my case, I was very lucky. I had Westbridge Capital, which you would know in Bangalore, Sandeep Singhal, who invested in me from 2015 all the way to 2018, 2019.

[Speaker 1] (10:25 - 10:27)

You also had Rakesh Jhunjhunwala for it.

[Speaker 3] (10:27 - 10:31)

Yeah, of course. Rakesh Jhunjhunwala invested in 2018, much later.

[Speaker 1] (10:32 - 10:37)

Are you saying VCs are the bigger demon in the room than public market retail clients?

[Speaker 3] (10:37 - 12:04)

No, I'm saying, as an entrepreneur, you know that there are a lot of terms you have signed on, which you don't necessarily like. Again, I want to clarify with me, my relation with Westbridge or Sandeep Singhal was fantastic. They were always very patient.

In 15 years, we never picked up the agreement and looked at it. But psychologically, once you go public, all these rights fall away, right? Because everybody has equal rights.

And I'm as answerable to one shareholder, one single shareholder having one single share as I am to you. It's kind of an empowering feeling is what I feel. And yeah, I think honestly, I'm enjoying it.

It has its own challenges. For example, quarterly pressures, every quarter results. I think the compliances take care of themselves after a point, right?

The hygiene happens. That's not so much of an issue. But it's also how you approach it.

Like I have tried in the last three years as a listed company, and that's what I've been sharing with a lot of entrepreneurs who list. It's not easy to walk the talk. But you have to do the right thing, what you genuinely believe is right versus trying to deliver the next quarter's result.

Even at sometimes if that is a short term pain. Second is you have to try and be as transparent and disclose as much as you want. So if a shareholder wants to call you and ask what you had for breakfast this morning, you should be ready to say.

[Speaker 1] (12:05 - 13:06)

I'll say this about Nitish. If I were to categorize him with a word cloud as a human being, I would say conservative. I'm not going to praise him because he's sitting in front of me.

I would say conservative. Last person I would assume will ever do anything reckless. I would also say very diligent, detail oriented, and believes in long term relationships.

We live in a world where things go up and down so quickly. So the big, big thing about Nitish is, you know, 10, 20, 30 years from now, he'll still be here. He might not be growing the fastest, but he will be doing the right thing slowly in the background, which strangely enough is a really rare thing, not just here, but everywhere in the world today.

[Speaker 3] (13:06 - 13:35)

You learn from your lessons, right? When I started, I was like 17, 18, right in the start of the dot com boom in 99 and the crash in 2000, right? So I learned my lessons very quickly then.

And I think the conservatism comes a bit from there, which is a good thing and a bad thing, right? Because it has its own handicap also, but it allows you to live to fight another day and sustain, which is a good thing.

[Speaker 1] (13:35 - 13:42)

Even my industry is like that, stock markets. It's all about living to fight another day. Sean, would you like to go next?

[Speaker 4] (13:42 - 14:10)

Yeah, why not? Yeah, I'm from South Korea. I was born in Pohang, which is like Southeastern coast city.

I was born from there, from, you know, from parents who are working for one of the largest company in the world. So I'm from the middle class family. That's my...

[Speaker 1] (14:10 - 14:18)

I'm guessing South Korean middle class is much more rich than Indian middle class. What is GDP per capita in South Korea? $50,000?

[Speaker 4] (14:19 - 14:21)

$33,000 now, I guess.

[Speaker 1] (14:21 - 14:24)

So middle class would be like $70,000, $80,000 a year?

[Speaker 4] (14:25 - 15:15)

Yeah, household income might be like that. But then you have to understand that Korea grows, grew quite fast. So when I was like, you know, 10, 15, it was...

I cannot say that it was similar to what Indian economy is now currently in position. But South Korea GDP, when there was an Olympic in 1988, it was $2,500, $2,600, $2,700, which is pretty similar to where India is. So as a South Korean, we started from like in 60s, 70s, before I was born.

It was a developing country in the lower side among global peers. And then it grew into a developed country in the...

[Speaker 1] (15:15 - 15:16)

What era are you talking about? Which year?

[Speaker 4] (15:16 - 15:38)

From 70s till maybe 2000. These 30 years, Korea maybe started from maybe 300, 400 GDP per capita and become now like, you know, 15,000, maybe 15,000 around like early 2000. So that was the journey, like Korean economy grew quite fast.

[Speaker 1] (15:38 - 15:40)

Do you have any North Korean friends or did you ever?

[Speaker 4] (15:41 - 15:50)

Not really. Like, it has been separated like more than 70 years now. And we are not allowed to visit North Korea legally.

[Speaker 1] (15:51 - 15:53)

Are there any North Koreans in South Korea?

[Speaker 4] (15:54 - 15:54)

Sorry?

[Speaker 1] (15:54 - 15:56)

Are there any North Koreans in South Korea?

[Speaker 4] (15:56 - 16:27)

Yeah, I mean, there are quite sizable defectors. Like they are defecting from North Korea through third party countries like China, Vietnam, Mongolia, Thailand. So I believe, I don't really remember the exact number, but I think at the peak there was 10,000 or 20,000 per year.

The North Koreans defecting North Korea to enter South Korea.

[Speaker 1] (16:27 - 16:31)

What's Korean society like today? I have never been. I would love to go.

[Speaker 4] (16:31 - 16:31)

Yeah, you should.

[Speaker 1] (16:32 - 16:36)

So you've been in India a while now. You live in Bangalore, where I also live.

[Speaker 5] (16:36 - 16:36)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (16:37 - 16:51)

If you had to draw parallels between society in Bangalore and society in South Korea, what is similar and what is dissimilar?

[Speaker 4] (16:53 - 17:44)

Like Korea, South Korea is a very quite homogeneous society. It's getting more cosmopolitan. There are more immigrants, especially from Southeast Asia.

But I think overall 97, 8% are all Korean in terms of population. And also, it's a small country. I think the land mass is around 100,000 square kilometers, which might be, I don't know, 20 times or 40 times smaller than India.

So all people speak only Korean. There's no Hindi speaking people. English speaking?

English, I mean, because of education, it has taken some time, but I think young Koreans speak fairly good English.

[Speaker 1] (17:44 - 17:46)

But it's still very much like the second language, is it?

[Speaker 4] (17:46 - 18:20)

Yeah, of course, of course. So in school, we, I mean, most of public school do not use English as a medium for teaching classes. So English has a separate sort of classes, which maybe three hours a week or something like that.

So English, but we spend a lot of money to learn English outside the class, outside the classroom. So, I mean, I also studied a lot of English outside the school. Which, yeah, which is still the case.

[Speaker 1] (18:20 - 18:21)

Do you live in Bangalore by yourself?

[Speaker 4] (18:22 - 19:46)

Yeah, I mean, half voluntarily and half involuntarily. It's kind of long story, but make it short. When I was working in HQ in Seoul, we start to get a sense, you know, how India is developing as a gaming country.

I think it was in 2019. I visited Nazara office. Also, I visited some other companies and VC firms office back then.

And we slowly think about, we need to properly spend time in India and invest in Indian companies and work within Indian companies. But that was starting from 2019. But the chairman, chairman of Krafton, he traveled to India way earlier than me, maybe 2017 or 18.

And after he came back from there, from India, he told us like the key executives in the company that we should do something in India. He didn't tell us how. He want us to find a way.

So, and then we started investment. And the first investment was a Nodwin, Nodwin Gaming, which is subsidiary of... Akshat.

Yeah, yeah, Akshat.

[Speaker 1] (19:46 - 19:53)

What do you think of Akshat? Yeah, I mean, like no one... Why is Animesh laughing?

What do you think of Akshat?

[Speaker 4] (19:53 - 19:54)

Maybe he doesn't like him.

[Speaker 1] (19:54 - 20:08)

He calls himself the professor and I think he's actually the professor. He's the professor of the industry. So I've been following Akshat for like good 10 years, even before I got into gaming professionally.

You know, when Nodwin used to... When Akshat himself was a caster, he used to cast in their own events.

[Speaker 4] (20:08 - 20:09)

Yeah, even Gautam.

[Speaker 1] (20:09 - 21:50)

Both of them used to cast their own events. I believe that he has changed the face of esports in India specifically. To be that consistent with the efforts when gaming was nothing in India, way back in 2014, is I think when he established Nodwin.

And then to take some massive steps like, you know, selling his majority to Nazara way back in the days. And then still having that same gist to build the company. And what Nodwin has been

doing over the last one and a half years specifically.

I think he's a person to look up to. And you know like, I was smiling because he's the only person at some point in my career I would want to, you know, stand shoulder to shoulder in the sense of the enterprise that I build. He's one of a kind of...

What are esports, Animesh, if I may ask? Esports is gaming in a competitive format wherein there are wins and losses. It's not about playing inside the game and winning and losing.

But there are teams, just like how we have in cricket. And you have a fixed set of players. There's a roster, there's a team.

And they're playing with high stakes with a big, priceful tournament. And what kind of games typically? It could be anything.

It could be FPS, which is like a CS that you used to play back in your days. Just say full forms. FPS is what?

FPS is First Person Shooter. Wherein, you know, the view format of the game is you have a gun in your hand and you can see a first person view. Is that the most popular kind of game in India?

Shooting? India, yeah. Shooting is very popular but third person shooting.

TPS. Like, you know, the game like... You can see the character fully and you're moving.

So Krafton. We know now Krafton was a $20 billion company. Now it's a $10 billion company.

Roundabout. How did you get into this industry? How are you Krafton CEO now?

How did you come to India?

[Speaker 4] (21:50 - 22:02)

Krafton India CEO. I really like to play games. I like playing games maybe since I was...

Not 7, maybe 8, 9, 10. So I maybe after grade 2 or grade 3. My father...

[Speaker 1] (22:03 - 22:03)

How old are you now, Sean?

[Speaker 4] (22:04 - 22:05)

45. 45.

[Speaker 1] (22:06 - 22:07)

In addition also?

[Speaker 4] (22:07 - 24:44)

Yeah. I think we are in the same age. 45?

Born in 78, right? 79. 79.

79. My father could afford buying... Back then it was Apple.

Apple compatible like 8-bit computer. So my father could afford it and honestly... Back then you said I want to learn how to programming and things like that but I didn't code too much.

I just played games all the time. So that was beginning of my passion on gaming as a hobby mostly. And then it grew quite a bit.

So I played a lot even in high school and college. And back then like Taiwan, like Israel South Korean man should go to army. But I...

Conscription. Conscription, yeah. It's a compulsory.

But we could choose to work for high-tech company, IT companies including gaming companies if you have certain engineering certificate after like college degree. So I try that direction. So I could get a job in game developer which still exists.

I could get a job there as a game designer. So that was my beginning of career in gaming. But I found that I'm not that good at game designing or coding so I switched my role to marketing and sales side.

And then and I that was how I got into the gaming side. But I actually didn't like working for gaming company. I found that it's something different.

You like playing games but you don't really like to work for gaming company. It was a little to be a little casual. It was shitty to work for a gaming company from young ambitious man perspective.

So I want to work for big companies so I switched to banking. How old were you then? Around 10 years after I had an MBA.

So I got a so I started my career in gaming in 2000. I got an MBA in 2008 and I started my career in banking from 2008 till 2017 which I joined Krafton as a CFO of one of the subsidiaries. So that's how I got into Krafton and then we were very successful in a game called PUBG and Did PUBG get banned in India?

[Speaker 1] (24:44 - 25:12)

You want to talk about PUBG? Yeah, I mean like it was more of a It was huge in India, right? Everybody was playing it.

Yeah, it's still big but now it's BGMI. Is it the same thing with a different name? No, it's an India oriented game that's made specifically for India and it's a different publisher altogether.

It has nothing to do with PUBG Mobile. That was a Tencent game. It was a Chinese company.

The biggest gaming company, you can call it. Tencent owns everything. Majority of the stuff.

What is the relationship between Tencent and Krafton?

[Speaker 4] (25:14 - 25:26)

Tencent is the investor. Tencent is an investor in Krafton before the IPO. And they still maintain some share.

So BGMI is also you?

[Speaker 1] (25:26 - 26:07)

Yeah. So you stopped PUBG to build BGMI and now that is popular? Like that?

PUBG is actually the original PUBG PC is a Krafton game. And then Tencent had the right to build the mobile version of it. And that's globally available PUBG Mobile.

When India banned PUBG Mobile, Krafton came with Indian version of their thing. They made their own thing, BGMI. Which is Battlegrounds Mobile India.

And what are the differences between these games? One is more appealing than the other? Technically nothing.

But then it's more about the origin and everything else that they have to address to launch the game in India. But China does that to everybody, right? They don't even allow Facebook and Google in China.

[Speaker 4] (26:07 - 26:23)

Yeah. And for gaming apps or like even before the mobile era, they allow publishing of games on the approval basis. Which is maybe China and Vietnam only in the world.

[Speaker 1] (26:23 - 26:49)

Do you feel like the world is becoming a more fragmented place? Taking inspiration from China? A country which does not allow foreign apps and replicates it with their own versions.

Will all IP that touches the citizens of a certain country in the future be built in the country or at least be owned or hosted in that country?

[Speaker 2] (26:50 - 30:22)

It's a really interesting question because I think that that was the direction we were going. And we may go back to that again. It was being called splinternet, basically.

Like the idea that because China has its own internal policies where you need a license, you also need a local partner. They were banning a lot of apps from the US. The current situation now, and there was a time when Trump was president of the US and he was going to ban TikTok, it seemed like we were going to be moving more in that direction.

We might again. But I do think that that's a danger. Actually, though, when it came to me starting a company here in India, that was a consideration.

Because we felt that if the world does move towards a splinternet and if China and Russia are on one side, I want to be on the other side. And if India is split from China, currently, one thing that's not well understood is that almost all of the top mobile shooter games are all developed by Chinese companies, effectively. Why is that?

It's because they have developed deep expertise in shooters. There's been a phenomenon in which the Tencent teams and the Chinese teams have just the work ethic, the culture, they're just kind of crazy compared to the West. The West right now, if I'm just being honest, we're going to be honest here, is in kind of a decline where you don't have the same work ethic, the same kind of drive.

And I think when you look at budgets today, in the U.S., budgets are, to make a game now is like $100, $300 million for an HD, a PC, or a console game. But in China, they're working 996. They've identified specific strategic areas that are important to them and then they just go all in in those areas.

And mobile for shooters has been one of those areas. And so when you look at every game that they work on, Call of Duty mobile is actually developed by Tencent, although they're using the IP of Activision, for example. Most of the, I would say that the skill, the technical expertise currently exists in China.

One of the objectives of the company that I started was to hopefully do that here in India as well. But it's been tough. Why is that?

I think that so the Indian game development ecosystem is still early. And if you look at the historical context of the Indian game development ecosystem, it's been one that's more, that has been more of a services orientation. And so the model in India, in terms of the historical context,

has been taking games from the West, at least from mobile, that are in decline, and then getting a team in India to live operate it for greater margins, for lower cost.

And so because of that historical context, there hasn't been a culture, a knowledge, a skill set of new game development in India yet. I'm sure it's burgeoning, and there's certainly a lot of successful local game companies.

[Speaker 1] (30:22 - 30:30)

Has there been a single game in India, built in India, that has reached scale in a true sense?

[Speaker 2] (30:31 - 31:09)

So I believe the game at the highest scale from a downloads perspective is GameShien's Ludo King. But really, it's GameShien. That's an Indian company?

Yes. When I look at the charts, that's the only game that I see come on the top charts globally. But still, it's largely an Indian audience, because there's so many Indians that love Ludo.

In what scale are we talking? In terms of revenue coming out of the game? I think that it has almost very little revenue, right?

From a downloads perspective, it's very high.

[Speaker 3] (31:09 - 31:16)

We recently crossed a billion downloads, I think, in India. Monetization is a challenge.

[Speaker 2] (31:17 - 31:34)

Right. And I think that's an opportunity for India, though, right? Which is, like, if India can develop a similar kind of work ethic, skill set, and knowledge of monetization and how to monetize more strongly, then I think India has a great opportunity.

[Speaker 3] (31:35 - 32:36)

You know, just to add to that, Nikhil, we've been around for so long, right? So we've really seen the whole evolution of the Indian gaming industry, right, from late 90s to where we are today in 24. I think one more reason is that unlike China, etc., which had a large PC gaming culture, gaming cafes, etc., for a very long period of time, India has really been a mobile gaming first nation. So most people playing games, the first experience has been the mobile phone. Very casual gaming. So just that culture takes time to develop, even when you're thinking as a game designer, as a game developer, as an evolution.

Up to 2010, you would not see that at all. Then you had Zingas of the world and Electronic Arts of

the world set up shop, back offices in Bangalore and Hyderabad, etc. And you've started seeing some of those come out, set up some companies which are now becoming successful.

So I think we're going up that curve. Hopefully we'll accelerate up that curve.

[Speaker 1] (32:37 - 32:54)

But I think he was making a good point. Joseph is saying there is the ecosystem in India is not capable of producing a game which can really compete on the world stage. What do you think India has to change to change that?

[Speaker 2] (32:54 - 35:05)

I think there has to be a few things that change. I would say probably the most important thing is talent. So look, I live in Silicon Valley, okay?

The smartest guys in Silicon Valley are all Indian. And so they certainly have, like Indians can be the smartest anywhere. All the tech CEOs are all Indian in Silicon Valley.

Do you think that's the problem? The smart ones are going out of the country? That's one of the problems.

But I think that gaming in India has a double problem. So first, yes. There are a lot of people in India when they get an opportunity to 7x, 10x their salary by going abroad and they have that opportunity because they've developed a skill set here then they'll jump.

I think the other thing is more of a cultural issue that I have discovered over the past few years that I've been here in India, which is that gaming, at least, and you guys please disagree with me, but in my experience, it seems like gaming is not looked upon favorably by a lot of Indian parents. And so when somebody wants to go into gaming, they really have to want to go into gaming. But otherwise, I think a lot of the parents, they typically would want to go to join some high tech firm, an Amazon, a Google, a Facebook, a company like that, rather than join a gaming company.

And so the image of a gaming company, unlike in the West, in the West, joining a game company is looked upon very favorably for a number of reasons. It generally leads in terms of innovation. A lot of the people that are in gaming actually are highly coveted by Facebook, Google, and the high tech companies.

But that kind of feeling and that kind of orientation towards gaming in the US versus India is so different. So then you not only lose talent overseas, but you also lose talent to other local Indian industries.

[Speaker 1] (35:06 - 35:16)

And what do you think should change in India to culturally make gaming or career in gaming look

cool?

[Speaker 2] (35:17 - 36:35)

I think it's more of an education, right? So I can name so many of my friends that went from gaming to join Facebook or Amazon or Netflix. And I think if some of the Indian employees here or people who are considering going into gaming understood, wow, I didn't know that those companies really sought people from gaming because gaming is so innovative and it is so cross disciplinary and you have to learn a lot of complex skills when you're in gaming.

So that is not well understood here. And I think that the other thing also that hasn't happened is that because again, the historical context of a lot of the Indian gaming companies has been more on the live ops and services orientation that there hasn't been the level of poaching or of the high tech companies trying to hire people out of Indian gaming companies yet. And I think when that happens, and I think that happens from people who have learned from the company building new games that are very successful, then they'll be poached fairly regularly or sought after.

I think that's when it becomes more popular.

[Speaker 1] (36:37 - 36:46)

Assume I'm a young 20 year old Indian boy, girl, and I want to get a job at Leela Games, your company, what should I learn?

[Speaker 2] (36:47 - 40:09)

Well, I think it would depend on the specific role that you're looking for. So if it's product management, I would be looking for one thing. If it's engineering, it'd be completely different.

But I would say a general bit of advice for anyone that's new looking to join a gaming company is to essentially think outside of the resume and to build, I call it a digital footprint, but basically show me what you know. Show me what you can do. That's just not lines on your resume.

So whether it's projects or whether it's blog posts where I can see how you think. Because I will say, having been recruiting here for the last three and a half years and having interviewed and looked at thousands and thousands of resumes, I would say that most people generally don't stand out because they don't actually show me anything that they've done that really tells me that they care about gaming, that they've thought about gaming. So anyone that has a blog post, a project that they've put onto a website, any kind of additional digital footprint outside of their resume really shows me that this is somebody that I need to pay attention to.

So I'll absolutely look at a resume with links to projects, blog posts, YouTube videos, anything of that nature more than just another resume, right? Would you like to tell us more about yourself, Joseph? Generally live?

I'm a guy that's trying to do something meaningful before I die. So in terms of my career, I kind of worked in software development initially. Then I moved into management consulting.

Then around 2010, 2011, started a gaming company unsuccessfully. Then went into really like consulting with big Asian publishers, trying to publish games, mobile games for the Western market. Why do they call them publishers?

Publishers generally finance and distribute games. So their model is to not do the development. They work with another company that actually develops the games, but then they would help get those games launched into market and distributed.

And so there's a financing component, but there's also a distribution and marketing component as well. Can you give me the example of a publisher and a game developer, the distinction? Sure.

So for example, I mean, I think Crafton recently, just to kind of give you a very live example, Crafton worked with a company called ZeptoLab that has a game for the global market, and they worked with them to make an Indian specific version of the game. So I don't know what the exact deal terms were, but I assume that they would pay for part or full development cost. They would have a revenue share with them, potentially give them a guarantee of some kind, some initial payment, and then it would be up to Crafton to actually market and distribute the game.

The developer, after they finished developing the game, would either, for a premium game, they'd be done. For a live-operated, free-to-play game, they would continue to operate the game and then share in the success of the game through a revenue share.

[Speaker 1] (40:12 - 40:21)

And when I read that you were at Sega Games, by Sega do you mean that console which we used to have back in the day? I remember playing that.

[Speaker 2] (40:22 - 41:30)

So after I kind of did consulting, I joined a company called FunPlus, and I actually had a pretty big success. And the model that I learned at FunPlus is the model that I'm actually trying to bring to India. And so at FunPlus we had something that I call a leads-based model.

But essentially we took, at that time, a fairly inexperienced team in Beijing. And this was during a period like 2000, I don't know, 14, 15 or so, when China was not as dominant as it is today. And we had a team in Beijing.

We brought experts from around the world in various areas that the team was not strong in. We brought them to China, had them teach the team, and then we developed games out of China. The game that I developed was called King of Babylon, but that turned out to be a pretty big success.

And then after FunPlus I joined Sega. Basically in their mobile games division. Was Sega the machine on which we used to play Contra, Mario and all that?

I've played a lot of that.

[Speaker 1] (41:31 - 41:32)

Contra, Mario Brothers.

[Speaker 2] (41:33 - 41:50)

Yeah, Sega exited hardware, the console business, a number of years ago but still develops games through a number of different game studios and is actually diversified in hotels, pachinko, and things like that. A lot of other things as well.

[Speaker 1] (41:51 - 42:08)

You know, funnily enough, when you mentioned earlier gaming centers, when I was a kid, growing up, I'm thinking age six or seven, there used to be gaming centers where there would be Sega machines and you would pay per hour and play Contra for an hour.

[Speaker 3] (42:09 - 42:11)

Arcade centers, yeah.

[Speaker 2] (42:12 - 42:22)

Oh, just to finish the loop, after Sega I joined NBC Universal, which is a big media company, and then started this company about three and a half years ago.

[Speaker 1] (42:25 - 43:41)

Moving to the youngest one here. Yeah, that's what I was thinking. I've had the shortest professional run in the gaming industry until now.

Your online name is 8BitThug. Where was that inspired from? Do you feel like you're a thug in real life?

Not really. People do think that I'm a little bit of like, have a bullish nature in the gaming industry, but that's not true. I think that's just because things that I've been luckily been able to do, which I'm very proud of across the last six years.

The name story is very simple. 8Bit was my clan name in a game called Clash Royale, which I was heavily invested into as a casual gamer. Not professionally.

I was pursuing my CA interns and I had something to do because I didn't want to step out and

spend a lot of time studying. That was a game I was heavily invested into. I made a clan 8Bit.

That's how the prefix of my name came in. And Thug is actually a short form of Thug Life, which is also from a song from a movie called Dictator. College days, nothing to do.

I said it's a good name. You know, getting fascinated by movies. And then actually when I used to play PUBG Mobile, it did not take 8Bit Thug Life as my full name.

So I left out life and it's 8Bit Thug and rest is history. Why 8Bit? 8Bit, my team name.

[Speaker 4] (43:42 - 43:46)

Then why did you pick 8Bit for your team name? Interesting question.

[Speaker 1] (43:46 - 44:07)

When I was playing Clash Royale, there were eight people from across the world who met in the game who founded 8Bit. So there was one guy from Austria, couple from US, one from Austria. So we used to call ourselves 8Bits of the entire clan system.

And then we all just fell off, they fell off and I just continued the name and established.

[Speaker 4] (44:07 - 44:13)

I thought that, thank you. I thought that you are like, you know, fan of classic games.

[Speaker 1] (44:13 - 44:14)

Oh no, not really.

[Speaker 4] (44:14 - 44:17)

I've always been fan of high graphic intensive games.

[Speaker 1] (44:18 - 47:01)

So I'm going to ask you most questions because you're the protagonist of the Indian gaming story in a way or the career in gaming. You came from a non-gaming background and today you're a professional gamer in India. So tell us the story from the beginning and then I'll ask you things like money, opportunity, all of that.

So how did you enter game? Right. So I'll go back to the beginning.

Actually I was, I come from a middle class family. My father is a chartered accountant. My sister is a chartered accountant.

I was pursuing. You're going to get trolled for calling chartered accountant middle class but

continue. Yeah, but it is a story.

When I realized right now that how I was in a middle class segment when my father was a CA but that's a different story. And I was pursuing CA. My life goal was inspired from Hrithik Roshan, ZNMD investment banker banne hai, Goldman Sachs.

I was doing CFA. I cleared CFA level 1. I pursued FRM.

I cleared its level 1. But I did all of this when I was shy of 24, like 6 years back. So I realized and I used to play a lot of games but not professionally.

Just play games, watch some of the biggest streamers at that point like Ninja, Shroud and a game called Fortnite which is still one of the very popular titles caught my attention. I don't know why, like today I have an answer why people watch games but then I did not have an answer and I used to wake up at 6.30am Indian time in Bangalore just to watch Ninja or these guys go live because of the time zone difference. Why?

I still don't get it. When I can play I guess one can say the same about sport. That's the answer.

The question itself has the answer. I have never watched anybody stream but I'm trying to wrap my head around why is it so much fun to watch someone play a video game. I think the nature of video games that's being played, the competitiveness that it brings, the storyline that it brings I think a lot of great content creators are great storytellers.

So they bring a different angle apart from the story that is within the game. So those are a few things that really holds the audience together and also the competitive side is the biggest part of it. So wait, somebody is watching a game there is a content creator on top of the game who is giving commentary and you are watching the commentary.

Right, because you know the way, I think when you play story mode games, story mode games are games which have a particular story and once you finish the story the game is done. You don't need to play it again. I think a lot of greatest content creators that I have seen are big gamers they are excellent storytellers.

Give me some examples. I think if you look at a story mode game, something like God of War a very popular game way back in my school days as well. I used to play it on the PS2.

So once the story is over, it's done. It's done. The game is done.

And then you move on to the next one.

[Speaker 2] (47:02 - 47:02)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (47:03 - 47:51)

And then there are games like GTA that go on forever. Then there have been games like Grand Theft Auto that go on forever. So that's one part of watching streams or content.

The second part is obviously when you play games like BGMI or Valorant which have a competitive angle to it, which have a win condition to it. So you know, when some of the famous names who have represented India who have played tournaments, won those tournaments and when they go out and show it to the public how it's done I think that really catches the attention of a lot of people. I think it has evolved over the last 3-4 years with a lot of fun elements because it's a very, you know, these games like BGMI, Valorant where you're playing as a squad it has a lot of fun elements to it because you're connecting socially to each other.

You're talking. So this conversation comes fun. I mean like why did we use, like even I have watched Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahuti.

What was it? It was just this conversation.

[Speaker 3] (47:51 - 47:52)

You were 28, no?

[Speaker 1] (47:52 - 53:48)

28. I watched it as a kid. It was my era, Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahuti.

No, but my era also. But I was in class 1. You must have seen the later Tulsi's and Mir's, not the original ones.

Yeah, possible. But I've seen all the deaths. I've seen 5 Mir's, I guess.

Not Smriti Rani. No, I've seen Smriti Rani. Yeah.

She was so good, right? Yeah, she was good. Definitely.

So I believe that that's the reason why people watch games. It's just about they play the game, they relate to it. It's like cricket.

You've played cricket. Everyone has played or at least heard a lot about cricket. Now you're getting to, when you see IPL, you get to see a different angle of cricket.

Believe me, T20 World Cup is never same as IPL. The masala that comes with IPL is the reason why so many people are glued to it. Like you know, it becomes a festival in India.

I think that's the case with people watching gaming streamers. You know, it becomes a different

version of that game for them. And while you're watching a stream, are you all talking to each other?

While I'm watching? If I'm a viewer, I'll be chatting with other people who are watching my stream. That's what happens on YouTube and Twitch or Loco as a matter of fact.

But as a player, if I'm playing a solo person, story mode game, then I might be not chatting with anyone else. But I'm playing squad games, I'll be chatting with my teammates. I'm going to blatantly ask a question.

As an Indian full-time gamer, how much do successful streamers, gamers make in India? How viable is it as a profession? I think it's very skewed, to be very honest.

The top gamers and top streamers make a lot of money. Like if you go to the bottom of the chart, people are not making money at all. Describe a lot.

Who's the number one streamer? Million dollars comfortably in a year. This is a gamer?

This is a gaming content creator. It has to be a streamer. Who's the top in India?

I think it could be Mortal, Scout, Mithpat. Like few million subscribers on YouTube. Millions of subscribers.

Then we have techno gamers. They are comfortably making money around that number. And this money comes from?

Brand endorsements plus content, I think. Brand endorsements really form a big chunk. YouTube content?

Yeah, YouTube content. YouTube or Instagram. Is it like PewDiePie?

I remember looking at YouTube for a long time. PewDiePie had the largest subscribers. This is like that?

Sort of. Yes. He has been an inherent gamer.

He has played games for quite a bit on his channel. So something of that kind. Okay, remove content creators.

Gamer, gamer? Gamer, gamer, I would say people who have played at the highest level of esports. That is playing official tournaments for a franchise.

Not a franchise. We don't have franchises. But for a registered esports team.

I think they could be doing close to 30-35 lakhs a year. By just playing games. Professionally.

And how many of these people are there? Thousands? Not really.

I don't think at 35 lakhs it's thousands. It could be the top 150. Because it's very limited.

Where else in this domain can young people make money in India? Streamer, gamer then? Okay, so now this is where I want to come to the conversation that you have with Joseph.

What I feel that India does not really... So if you look at Indian market gaming boomed in India 2019. It's exactly when it started booming and COVID happened and the gaming industry just blew off the lids.

I believe if you compare Indian gaming trajectory to western and European market. Like European and American market you realize we paced in, you know the graph was very steep. We moved at a very fast pace.

We paced really well. Gaming in India grew by lips and bounds compared to the pace at which other countries were coming in. But that is the consumption part of it.

India surpassed US and Brazil in terms of mobile game downloads. India has 568 million online gamers. So numbers are great.

But there was a big void in the system which was this. That we did not have the proper correct roles defined. People did not know what jobs are available.

But people did not know apart from being a mortal or a scout or becoming a gamer, there are other 100 domains where you can enter the gaming industry. So I believe that we are too young for that. The industry is too young for that.

India will produce the best of games in coming years but it's not going to happen at least for the next 5 years. Why? I believe that building games is super expensive.

From what I have studied, I might be wrong and someone can correct me. I don't believe there were enough funds in India funding game development in India. Gaming just like all the gaming funds, even Krafton's Incubator was announced early this year and then there's Mika and then I think even MPL is building a game.

But all of this happened in the last 3-4 years. So if there were dreams you know when we talk about exodus, talent exodus from India. If there were dreams 8 years back about building game in India who would fund it?

That's the point. You know I was just speaking to your one of your teammates. I feel like money always follows talent.

It does but then I believe that there needs to be a base for that ecosystem. I mean like 8 years

ago if someone would have gone and said I need 2 million dollars or 3 million dollars to build a game no one would have given that person that money. I believe that.

I could be wrong but that's what I feel because I watched the industry only for the last 7-8 years. So I think that is the problem. So I think right now it's doing good.

The money has just started to come in. There are small studios that are trying to work really hard and we'll have a good game and we'll have that point where we hold India's talent to India and build good games. And also if you look at it, even he was mentioning it that China has a stronghold.

Tencent makes games that no one else can do it. That is one problem that the entire world is facing. So I believe that India will make it smart but we need to give it time to breathe.

Like let it breathe. Let this industry breathe. We have talents.

We have people who are now keen on developing games because now they see the money coming in. I believe you said money follows talent. I believe in India talent goes where the money lies.

Both ways. It's actually both ways.

[Speaker 2] (53:49 - 54:14)

But I would say that if you look at Turkey for example, right? You had a few studios that had pretty big success there. Peak Games and now Dream Games.

And then now there's a flood of money rushing to Turkey, right? So similarly, if India had just a few successes on a global stage, I'm sure there would be a rush of money that would come here as well. There's already a number of global funds, right?

[Speaker 1] (54:15 - 54:22)

There hasn't even been one outside of Ludo? There's been Raji which did pretty well. Raji.

It's a game that was launched on Steam.

[Speaker 4] (54:23 - 54:24)

But then it's an indie.

[Speaker 1] (54:25 - 54:36)

But it did okay-ish. And I believe that what now Indus is Super Gaming is building Indus. It's a very promising title.

Even MPL is doing UGW, Underworld Gang Wars.

[Speaker 5] (54:36 - 54:37)

So let's see.

[Speaker 1] (54:37 - 54:56)

I think there are games coming out. And I believe that India will have great games come out. Because I've seen Indian gamers are built different.

We haven't had our cricket moment of 83 yet for Indian esports. But once that happens, the boom should come in. Are the incumbent Indian market leaders helping out?

Like Nitish on your right?

[Speaker 5] (54:58 - 55:00)

Good question. Definitely.

[Speaker 1] (55:01 - 1:00:00)

I got great help from Nordwin. And I'm shooting for Krafton tomorrow. I have a shoot at 6am.

So if I were a 20-year-old young guy or girl, how do I make money in gaming? I love gaming. I play it in my free time.

My parents and my peers are giving me a hard time saying that I'm wasting time and money and resources gaming. What is the path to build a successful career? Path of least resistance in gaming.

So I'll talk about the path to becoming a gamer. Very hard truth. If you're a 20-year-old, I've said it on record and I always say it.

Gaming cannot be the only thing that you're pursuing in India right now. You need to have a backup. You need to have a backup plan if you're come from a business family or pursuing your studies, you need to continue doing that.

Continue gaming as a passion until you are at the right place, in front of the right person and at the right stage where you get to show your gaming talent. When I talk about India's top gamers, professional gamers or content creators, I believe they're nothing. There could be hundreds, thousands, lakhs of more skilled gamers and better content creators sitting at home.

But it's so much about luck that they were at the right place at the right time. The timing matters so much. I wouldn't have been sitting here if I wouldn't have taken that break for a year from my

academic career.

Plus that the game, I started streaming on 28th July. But if you don't do it full time, how do you compete with the international ones doing it full time? Coming to the international stage is a very very long story.

If you're actually getting a chance to compete, that means you've made it nationally. I'm saying to make it nationally also, it's a very big luck factor. Because...

What is talent? I know in cricket, talent is timing. Time.

Maybe you have more time before you hit a ball. Body, physical strength, all of that. What distinguishes one gamer from another in terms of talent?

Understanding of the game, the biggest thing. I think every game which is competitive in nature has so many strategical aspects to it that you need to give it real time to understand it. And believe me, a person who gives a lot of time, there's a thing called meta.

Meta is like what is something that is dominating the game right now? So, how does a meta change? What is that strategy that changes?

There is someone spending so much time on the game to bring out something different that gets him a win condition. Like he starts winning games. And that's when everyone else adopts it.

So I think talent is about that strategical input that you're bringing to a game. Apart from that, if you're playing a first person shooter or shooting game, the reflexes matter. How fast you react to situations.

So I had an another agenda today, like an ulterior motive almost. Our audience who we speak to are upcoming entrepreneurs in India who are trying to build a business. We try and give them information about different industries.

We have a grant program where we try and give them some funding. Somebody really young who wants to build something with promise. And we also try and connect them from a community standpoint.

So we will put you guys in front of a bunch of really inquisitive people who want to be in gaming and make it a career. So the first thing I wanted to know is, where is young India spending time? You guys have the gaming lens.

If I were to make the assumption, not assumption, I think there's data for this. People under the age of 30 in India are spending a lot more time on social media. They're spending a lot more time on gaming.

They're spending less time watching TV. They're spending strangely less time watching sport. So

the amount of time somebody really young is spending on cricket is lesser than it was 10 years ago, 15 years ago.

They're spending lesser time playing physical sports or physical activities. Print media is going down. Online media is going up.

But not enough to totally compensate for print media going down. So if I'm a young 16 year old boy, I have 8, 10, 12, 3 hours in a day. Let's say 8.

How much time of that 8 is going where? Today. Where was it yesterday?

And where will it be at tomorrow? This is essential for anybody looking to build any kind of company in India. Because we need to know where the youth are going to be spending time tomorrow.

So I'll go to each one of you. And we don't have to narrow our lens down to India. You could talk about America.

You could talk about Southeast Asia. Who would like to go first? Sure.

[Speaker 3] (1:00:01 - 1:00:59)

I can go first. So I think if I go back to my own generation, and if I go back to my school days when I was 15 or 16, or even younger, cricket was where our life would revolve around. You would play cricket all the time with your building friends.

You would watch cricket. I remember in school I would even wake up at 5 in the morning to watch a test match happening in South Africa or Australia before going to school. Your whole life revolved around this thing called cricket.

I especially think the younger you are getting, and your question was below 30, right? But I have a thesis here that the younger you get, the velocity or the amount of time being spent on gaming is increasing. Right?

So 15-16 year old today is probably spending maximum time on social media, some on sports, and a decent amount of time on gaming.

[Speaker 1] (1:01:00 - 1:01:12)

The stats say 40% of their time on social media, and maybe 30% on gaming. But the rate of change in time spent is going up in social media even faster than gaming.

[Speaker 3] (1:01:12 - 1:01:34)

No, but if you go even a little younger, I'm saying from experience, I've got two young kids who

are below 12. Social media, they're not even allowed to be honest, a lot. But the rest of their time is only gaming.

And what games are they playing? They've evolved. First they used to play my games, which was Kidopia, which is very popular.

So I'll do a shameless plug.

[Speaker 5] (1:01:34 - 1:01:35)

I like how you plug in.

[Speaker 3] (1:01:36 - 1:03:11)

I've been playing for three years. No, no. But now they've moved to Minecraft.

Right? So both the kids are playing Minecraft. Okay.

Sitting next to each other. They wake up at 6 o'clock in the morning. I wake them up sharp at 6 in the morning, where they will leave for school at 7.

The first thing they'll do is pick up their respective iPads and start Minecraft. 6 to 6.30 is their gaming time. There will be a wake-up alarm, you can say.

So they'll do Minecraft. But the more important thing is, on YouTube or on the TV, they're on YouTube and watching Minecraft videos. They're watching Minecraft streamers.

Then my daughter recently had a birthday, so I asked her, what birthday theme do you want? And she wanted to do... How old is your daughter?

She's just 7. She wanted a theme. She said, Aptmau.

I didn't even know what is Aptmau, so I Googled it. It's supposedly a girl called Jessica in the US, who's a popular Minecraft streamer. And she wanted a whole birthday theme around that.

Streamer, right? And we have merchandise around that streamer now, so she wants me to buy that. What I realized is, for these younger kids, what cricket was for us has been replaced by gaming.

With their friends, the topic of discussion is gaming. What are you doing? Which game?

Etc. It's all revolving around gaming. And therefore, I'm betting that as this generation grows up, which is your today's 5-year-old, 10-year-old, into the next 4-5 years, where gaming will be by far the primary source of...

[Speaker 1] (1:03:11 - 1:03:16)

But why not social media? Because when they grow to be 16, you'll allow them and they'll graduate to that, right?

[Speaker 3] (1:03:16 - 1:03:30)

Probably they will, but I think they will still be far more ingrained, because they've done this gaming from the age of 2. My daughter started gaming at 1 and a half. So I think it comes very naturally to them, rather than adopting to it as a lot of the current generation has.

[Speaker 1] (1:03:30 - 1:03:50)

So if I am 20 and I want to sell something when I'm 25, I'm building a business, I'm an entrepreneur, wannabe entrepreneur. Do you think I should focus on gaming, social media, sport, movies, TV? What audience should I be building for?

Two words.

[Speaker 3] (1:03:50 - 1:04:28)

If you want to sell to the audience, I think gaming is a great place because the kind of engagement you have on gaming, right? When you're playing a game, you're very focused and interacting with the game versus watching it passively. Let's say watching content passively.

So if you're selling to a gamer, it's a big potential, which is why something we've been looking at is what is a new word coming up, G-Commerce, right? Which is selling via games. It's a new trend which is starting to pick up and we'll see where it goes.

[Speaker 1] (1:04:30 - 1:05:30)

And how do I sell to a gamer? Say I'm starting a chocolate company and I want to sell, I think the gaming crowd will be three times as big as they are today in 10 years. How do you start selling to them?

Do you go to Discord, Twitch, streaming platforms, chat boxes? I think the best way is in-game monetization. You know, I think that if the crowd is shifting, the trend is shifting towards spending more time on games, they would want to market it inside the game.

I mean, like, if you look at Hero, your recent partnership that you announced yesterday, I'm guessing Hero will bring their bike skins within the game. And if they are targeting it for the Zen-Z, the 125R model, I think they've hit the right chord because like we see, people are not spending time on TV, if people are not watching cricket, and if they're spending time on social media and gaming, then you just split your spends into the two things. You have your ads running and then you have things that they're spending time on integrated into it.

So I believe that is the best way to go about it, but you will have more insight.

[Speaker 4] (1:05:30 - 1:05:44)

Yeah, I have a very good example. Like, my kids love to watch MrBeast on YouTube. Kids are getting crazy.

And then I think he has built some brands. Chocolate.

[Speaker 5] (1:05:44 - 1:05:44)

Yeah.

[Speaker 4] (1:05:45 - 1:06:15)

Festival, chocolate. They, my kids don't really remember Hersh. But kids remember Feastables.

So when I went to GDC, just a few weeks back, their request, just only one thing, buy lots of Feastables chocolates. So that they can have it, also they can give out to friends. So it's also kind of like showing kind of status.

Like, I have Feastables which can be bought from the U.S. and then give it to friends. It's big.

[Speaker 3] (1:06:16 - 1:06:24)

I paid like a thousand bucks for a Feastable, which tastes the same like Amul Choc. They're the same, but different labels.

[Speaker 2] (1:06:25 - 1:08:14)

Nikhil, I've got a very different perspective. Nikhil, I think one other way to think about opportunity for a young person is, and certainly I think one way to think about it is current kind of demand side. But the other way to think about it is more on the supply side and also in terms of new demand.

And I think the one thing that cannot be ignored in my opinion, and I believe we're living in a very unprecedented time is essentially AI. And if you see the growth of AI today, and we were at GDC, the number of people building tools and capabilities with AI is incredible. It's moving so fast.

So if I were to advise somebody younger, I would say that in my opinion I think AI is going to be as big as the internet, potentially bigger in terms of impact to society. And so from that lens I think that you want to be thinking about a cross strategy. Meaning you want to learn AI as a base, but then cross it with something else.

What does that mean? For example AI cross gaming. So you're going to learn AI, but then you're

also going to develop depth in a different industry or sector so that you can take the AI capabilities and bring that to that sector.

So whether it's AI cross gaming or banking or pharmaceuticals or whatever. So then you would, I would recommend for younger people to find an area of interest, but then also develop their expertise and knowledge in AI so that they can take those capabilities into that space. And then I think besides that the one other thing that we're seeing is a fundamental shift.

And so for people who are watching that are interested in gaming, I think the big shift that is happening is from a development perspective.

[Speaker 1] (1:08:15 - 1:08:26)

Before you go there, if I were to try and incorporate AI into my vocabulary as a gamer, as a young gamer, what tools should I get familiar with? What should I learn?

[Speaker 2] (1:08:27 - 1:09:19)

Well, I would say like in the current state, I would probably learn all of the tools. For example? So whether it's ChatGPT or Cloud3 or some of the newer tools that are being developed using those.

There's a lot of applications in gaming in terms of like conversational AI and things of that nature. So there's a lot of services being developed. So becoming familiar with the services and the capabilities that are being developed.

But on top of that to then learn AI in more depth. So what is a large language model? What are the kind of models that are out there today, whether it's LLAMA or other open source models and things of that nature.

So what I would recommend for AI is basically extreme depth. Learn as much as you can at a foundational fundamental level. And then again that other industry.

[Speaker 1] (1:09:20 - 1:09:30)

And if you had to name two subsets of AI that I should begin focusing on specifically for gaming what would they be?

[Speaker 2] (1:09:31 - 1:11:00)

I think the biggest push right now is conversational AI. You wouldn't say something like Unreal Engine? I think Unreal and Unity are game development engines.

And so I don't think those they're trying to build some AI capabilities there. For example to potentially write code or to automate things. But I don't think AI has as big of an impact on the game engines as they would probably more on a UGC platform.

So I think you'll start as UGC? User generated content. And so if you were to look at some of the UGC platforms, the user generated content platforms like Roblox or UEFN, which is Epic's version of Roblox.

Can you just explain? I'm a layman. What is...

So Roblox is the world's biggest user generated content platform. Basically what Roblox is, is a platform in which actually many kids go and they build game experiences based upon a set of tools that Roblox provides into the Roblox game world. And so you can go to Roblox and there's a bunch of different games that the creators have made.

So in Roblox, creators that are often very young will create these games using the tools that have been provided by Roblox. And Epic now has something similar called UEFN. Unreal Engine for Fortnite.

Which kind of builds these experiences within Fortnite.

[Speaker 1] (1:11:00 - 1:11:04)

And I don't need any prior knowledge to be able to utilize these?

[Speaker 2] (1:11:04 - 1:11:25)

You need some depth of understanding. So like Roblox for example uses a scripting language called Lua. So there is some knowledge required.

But I would say the user generated content platforms are also a way in which someone from India could make potentially millions of dollars. I think like the top creator.

[Speaker 3] (1:11:25 - 1:11:57)

I just want to add there because I've been very actively involved in that whole thing right now. What he's referring to. I just did a Zoom call recently with a 19 year old kid who has a game called Blocks Fruits.

And it makes something like $60 million a year or something in revenue. After that I've been trying to migrate my kid from Minecraft to Roblox. Everyday I try that.

Right? So it's absolutely crazy. And he's absolutely right.

[Speaker 1] (1:11:57 - 1:12:12)

Okay tell me that kid. 19 year old. Me idiot.

Don't know anything about gaming. Know little bit about computers. Can't code nothing.

Step 1, Step 2, Step 3, Step 4. That kid making 60 million. Name those 4 steps.

[Speaker 3] (1:12:13 - 1:12:22)

No I mean coding is one thing right? Understanding some of these. But these kids are kind of hackers right?

They've done it hands on.

[Speaker 2] (1:12:22 - 1:13:20)

But I'm not. How do I do it? So I would say like first you need to learn the platform and then learn the kinds of things that the Roblox players are looking for.

And so the experience on Roblox is different from a mobile game. It's different from other kinds of games because it's very social in nature. And people are in Roblox to not just play but to meet and interact with other players.

And so step 1 would be learning Roblox, understanding the kinds of games that are popular and forming a hypothesis on why they are popular. And this is not complicated. I can spend X amount of time.

There are 13 year old kids making games on Roblox. It's not that complicated. And the second thing would be to learn the tools, Lua and the Roblox creator platform.

And I think the third thing would just be to just go. Just build as many games as you can and to then get those repetitions as far as like building and learning your craft and experimenting to see what works and what doesn't work.

[Speaker 4] (1:13:21 - 1:14:08)

I mean, if I may add, my kids actually trying to make game on Roblox. So the first you I mean, if I may answer to your question, you have to love playing games on Roblox or any other platform first. So you play maybe 100 different kinds of games first.

You like this, you don't like that. And then it's a very human nature, like if you like certain board game or certain game outside your home, you want to change a little bit and make it more fun with your friends. That is very same thing happening in Roblox and Minecraft.

There are some games that you like, then you want to create something similar, but in your own way. That's how actually I think things are starting.

[Speaker 3] (1:14:09 - 1:14:52)

It's great. And just I wanted to also highlight that the AI he spoke about on UGC, right? And I was

just hearing the podcast of the founder of Roblox and they're talking about now introducing or they've introduced or they're talking about launching soon.

Is real time translation? So when the kids are talking to each other, let's say I'm an Indian and there's another Japanese kid and I'm talking in Hindi to you Japanese kid is going to translate in real time. So kids can actually talk in their own language and communicate translates Hindi into Japanese.

And it's fantastic. So the way AI is being used in such applications to actually bridge and connect.

[Speaker 1] (1:14:52 - 1:15:02)

I have one confusion here. You were not talking about creating content around the game because you said UGC, you're talking about actually building the game.

[Speaker 2] (1:15:03 - 1:15:19)

Yeah, I think there's a couple of different opportunities, right? So there is an opportunity that we haven't talked about, which is building games for UGC platforms. And name a UGC platform.

Roblox and UEFN. Those are the two biggest right now. When you see UGC, my head is going to YouTube.

[Speaker 3] (1:15:20 - 1:15:22)

User generated content. Right, right.

[Speaker 1] (1:15:22 - 1:15:23)

It could be anything.

[Speaker 2] (1:15:23 - 1:18:16)

And I think we see plenty of examples of games built by kids that are making tens of millions of dollars, like a dot may probably makes like 70 million to that team. So that's certainly an opportunity. And then there's the opportunity that I think is more general outside of UGC platforms, which is just by understanding AI and gaming to then find a specific opportunity to apply AI to gaming.

And I think certainly what we're going to see is we're going to see a massive shift in how development occurs. It's going to change dramatically and radically. And as I mentioned, this kind of depends on your perspective of the world, but I actually think that this is going to be an incredibly rare moment in time.

And probably, you know, I believe unprecedented in history where you're going to have the

opportunity for some kid in India to become like a billionaire as a single person company, right? Because one of the things that we're seeing is this shift from what I call like long vector development, by vector I mean time, cost, resources, things like that, to small vector development. And so today you've got a lot of games that have huge budgets, 100, 200, 300 million with huge teams.

But the promise of AI, and it's hard to see right now because it's hard for people to think exponentially. But when you see the numbers, this is like when Jeff Bezos started Amazon. He saw the dramatic growth in adoption of the internet.

When you see that kind of, what we're currently seeing is we're seeing that growth start to happen and that investment starting to happen. But as that happens, you're going to be able to then have very small teams build incredible games that have massive reach, massive distribution. The mobile platforms, iOS and Google Play, they have billions of people, right?

They're billion person platforms. We've also had an example where, talking about UGC, there was a creator that learned their skills on Roblox, but then created a mobile, sorry, created a PC game called Lethal Company that became a number one game on Steam. Similarly, I do think that this is a new era and this is the time where I hope that the young Indian people out there listening to this podcast will kind of wake up and realize that this moment in time in history is very rare.

This is the time for them to really focus, learn, and to make something great because I don't think there's going to be that many more opportunities in the world after this.

[Speaker 1] (1:18:17 - 1:18:41)

After this is done, can we all in consultation put out a process doc of recommendations of what a young person needs to learn? They say mid-core and core is 0.4 billion, casual and hyper-casual is 0.7 billion. Can you explain what that means?

Anyone? Sean?

[Speaker 4] (1:18:42 - 1:18:54)

Mid-core hardcore games include VGMI and maybe other shooter games and some of sports games, simulation games.

[Speaker 1] (1:18:55 - 1:19:01)

So how do you justify this mid-core? How do you categorize mid-core? This 0.4 billion?

[Speaker 4] (1:19:01 - 1:19:21)

Mid-core games require quite focused attention. And a lot of investment? To make the game.

Generally, yes. But there is also a big range, but compared to typical hyper-casual or hybrid casual games, it requires more resources.

[Speaker 2] (1:19:22 - 1:19:32)

You guys want to comment? My only understanding of the Indian market is that it does seem that it's highly skewed to shooters. It does seem like shooters are making the majority of the money in India.

[Speaker 1] (1:19:33 - 1:19:35)

They fall in mid-core? In that bucket?

[Speaker 2] (1:19:36 - 1:19:46)

Mid-core, yeah. And then it seems like the rest of the money is being made from like Ludo as well as like Cricket and things like that.

[Speaker 1] (1:19:46 - 1:19:51)

Actually, it's a surprising number for me that mid-core and core market is so big because hyper-casual is understandable.

[Speaker 3] (1:19:51 - 1:19:51)

Not so big.

[Speaker 1] (1:19:52 - 1:19:58)

0.4 billion. 400 million for India. 400 million for India is still, I feel that it's pretty big that, you know.

[Speaker 3] (1:19:59 - 1:20:00)

Most of it he takes. Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (1:20:03 - 1:20:05)

What's your market share for BGMI?

[Speaker 4] (1:20:06 - 1:20:12)

BGMI, I would say 5-10%.

[Speaker 1] (1:20:12 - 1:20:12)

That's all?

[Speaker 4] (1:20:13 - 1:20:14)

He's being modest.

[Speaker 1] (1:20:18 - 1:20:20)

Is the money going back to South Korea?

[Speaker 4] (1:20:21 - 1:20:31)

Some of it, yes. But we invest in Indian tech startup. He invests in completely Nizana.

He can always invest more.

[Speaker 1] (1:20:31 - 1:20:39)

Okay, so I got an understanding of what is mid-core. What is casual and hyper-casual? Which is growing the fastest apparently.

[Speaker 2] (1:20:40 - 1:20:46)

Well, I think hyper-casual is dying down but it's really like the level of complexity is another way to think about it.

[Speaker 1] (1:20:47 - 1:20:50)

Are you saying casual and hyper-casual need lesser money?

[Speaker 2] (1:20:51 - 1:21:11)

Generally to build because they're simpler games, less complexity. I would say that the other kind of nuance behind those games is they typically have lower what's called retention days. So like a hyper-casual game often might retain a user for like 5 days.

But I think hyper-casual is starting to die.

[Speaker 1] (1:21:11 - 1:21:20)

Give me some examples. I think Candy Crush and Counter-Strike. Hyper-casual, casual is Candy Crush.

Mid-core, core is... Candy Crush is more casual.

[Speaker 2] (1:21:21 - 1:21:42)

Hyper-casual is more like Voodoo. Yeah, the Voodoo games. I would say even Ludo is more casual rather than hyper-casual.

Hyper-casual typically has a bunch of forced ads and things like that. Example? The old examples were like Snake.io and the old Nokia phones.

[Speaker 4] (1:21:42 - 1:21:46)

Pac-Man? Pac-Man is also still casual.

[Speaker 1] (1:21:46 - 1:21:50)

But why is that dying? That seems like the simplest thing for people to...

[Speaker 2] (1:21:50 - 1:22:03)

I don't know how deep you want to go because we can go very deep here. But it has to do with mainly Apple and basically this thing called IDFA. We're really going to go into this.

[Speaker 5] (1:22:04 - 1:22:04)

Give us a summary.

[Speaker 2] (1:22:04 - 1:22:24)

The summary is you can't do targeting anymore because of Apple's privacy policies. And so the ability for the hyper-casual games that are largely driven off of the ad-driven model to then make money off of those ads through targeting is going away. And Apple just doesn't like hyper-casual games.

[Speaker 1] (1:22:24 - 1:22:33)

I'll tell you this. When I used to play Snake on my old Nokia 3310 phone, there was no advertising. It came bundled with the phone.

[Speaker 2] (1:22:34 - 1:22:52)

Right, and it kind of morphed into a model where you have a super casual gameplay experience but throwing in a bunch of ads has been the current manifestation of how hyper-casual evolved into.

[Speaker 1] (1:22:52 - 1:22:57)

So is that ad model moving from ad to in-app purchases?

[Speaker 2] (1:22:58 - 1:23:16)

Yes, so now it's moving more to what's being called hybrid-casual. Can you explain? And hybrid-casual is more of a hybrid between more of a casual or mid-core game and a hyper-casual game

with less reliance on advertising because of things like the lack of targeting because of privacy and things like that.

[Speaker 1] (1:23:17 - 1:23:45)

So if I were building a game today, let's say I followed the three steps that we would put out from... I would ignore hyper-casual. I would not look at it at all.

So say a young guy has done the NVIDIA free course, the Michigan University free course. He's on Roblox. He has learned how to create a game.

Now when I start building the game, should I plan to monetize my game via in-app purchases versus pay-to-play?

[Speaker 2] (1:23:45 - 1:27:25)

So it depends on the game, right? So I would say if you're making more of a mid-core to hardcore game, it's generally a heavier IAPCU. What is IAPCU?

IAP is just in-app purchase. So not advertising-based. And then the more casual to hyper-casual it is, the more advertising you would integrate into the game.

But I think to the point on if you were learning AI and trying to figure out how to apply it, you could apply it to making a game. You could apply it to figuring out a completely new kind of game to make using AI. For example, like Dungeons and Dragons where the AI is suddenly the dungeon master.

Now it can do all the campaigns for you, right? There's going to be new capabilities and new games that are enabled because of AI. And the third area of opportunity would be looking at AI and trying to pick a specific segment in the game development process that you can help reduce the cost of or automate through AI.

Explain. For example, in game development, there's a lot of different teams that do different things. So there's engineering, there's art, there's product management.

But if you could use AI to provide a better tool or to automate one of the workflows there. For example, right now coders can use AI tools to help write code for them. Also, AI is being used to generate manuals.

Product managers can use AI to do data analysis by just dumping in spreadsheets and saying visualize some stuff for me. So there's a lot of different things that AI can be applied to. And so then it would be figuring out, okay, what is a big problem that I can apply AI against?

Can you give me a low-hanging fruit that you think is an opportunity today? Well, I can give you specific examples of what people are doing right now. The big thing right now, there's two

companies, InWorld and Convey, that have been funded for conversational AI.

Meaning, right now, NPCs in games, the non-player characters. So in an MMO, you can go to a shop and then there's a shopkeeper that talks to you. The dialogue that happens often, whether it's an in-story character or with a shopkeeper that has a very limited amount of dialogue is through a dialogue tree.

And so you can use these behavior trees to code what is said and not said. Or you could use a large language model and give the background behind a character in a large language model, understanding the context of the game and that character that they're supposed to personify can then just naturally respond to people in real time. So that's one application.

There's other applications where there's a company that's trying to automate the art process. Where you think of a character or a building, you create the model for it, you put it in the game and things like that. There are some companies that are just trying to make it so that you do sketches and then it just automatically goes into the game and completes the whole workflow.

So there's a lot of different areas that you can potentially apply AI to. And again, this is why it's like the cross something. So I want to learn product management in gaming super well and then try to figure out areas to attack.

Or I want to learn art super well and figure out areas to attack.

[Speaker 1] (1:27:26 - 1:30:16)

That's the way I would be thinking about it. Nimesh, after listening to this, where do you think the opportunity is for someone young? I still feel obviously this is a very big opportunity.

It's futuristic from all I've read, all I've seen. But I believe that if someone wants to start building a game tomorrow and actually go out in the market in the next 3-4 years, that data is going to be very important. I think the way you mentioned that 40% of time is going to social media, I think that is very key to India sticking to mobile gaming and my generation people, the younger generation, sticking to mobile phones.

So I think even if I look at my gaming journey and how I got into games after a break from gaming for a good 7-8 years, I think after class 8, I haven't played too much games until I got into college and had some free time and as away from home. So it all started with Facebook and then I started playing maybe a Zynga game inside Facebook and then on Facebook I got maybe a recommendation of a Supercell game which was Boom Beach. And then I went into Boom Beach, but the reason why I started playing, continued to play in Boom Beach was there's a big social element attached to that game where I could chat with different people, make a clan, we could strategize, although it was within the game.

However, what happened next is that I took that entire set of audience, we exchanged our numbers within the game or we went to a Discord server, but then we were always socially connected. We were chatting, we were conversational. If I also look at, so, and that's been the trend in India at least, which I can say very confidently, that people love playing games, which has an element where they can connect with existing friends or meet new people.

So you're saying not so much mid-core games, but more casual with mobile first. Casual, mobile first and needs to have a social meeting element to it. And how easy or hard is it to build that?

I think it's difficult, not easy to hit the right chords with Indian audience, especially and with the culture also. It's like, you know, I believe that there are a lot of nuances that they need to be careful about when you bring the social element of being connected online. And it, I think there's going to be a lot of scrutiny, a lot of tapings that when they go to build that game.

What is the taping? Sorry? What is the taping?

I meant that, you know, there's going to be a lot of problems when they try to have two random people connect online because I believe a lot of games are facing this trouble even today. With respect to bullying happening online or cases that we have had because of people not knowing each other but connecting within games. So I believe that those are the key things that need to be sorted and because Indian gaming development market is still evolving, so these are a few things that they won't be able to solve when they're building in India for India.

So you're saying young people in India want to solve for both community and time pass? Correct. That should be the key factor and that is where I believe that Sean can answer why BGMI is so successful.

Like what are those key aspects?

[Speaker 4] (1:30:18 - 1:31:35)

My understanding, I mean people, different people might have different opinion I think about BGMI or like similar games. I think it has very good largely speaking there are two elements for the success. I believe maybe you guys can add.

So one thing is social aspects, definitely. It is most fun when you are playing with the other squad members, other three members as a team which you can keep talking through the voice chat over the like 30 minute or 40 minute session which give a good reason for playing another session, another session maybe tomorrow or next week, next weekend. That is one factor and second factor is unpredictability.

It is mostly like the similar elements in many multiplayer games but I think the Battle Royale genre itself, it has large open, not really fully open but large map like 8 by 8, 8km by 8km so there

are a lot of elements of unpredictability and less repeatability so every gameplay feels different. You cannot really make it if it is a story based game. If you play 10 hours, 20 hours then it's finished.

[Speaker 2] (1:31:35 - 1:35:05)

I've got a slightly different perspective. I'd love to hear your take on this, Sean. I don't know if I've ever talked to you about this before but I believe that games are actually a manifestation of a latent human desire.

So I think that people generally have in their psychology a need for something and so I believe that games allow people to manifest those desires in some way. Which psychological desire though? So let me give you a few examples.

So the 35 year old soccer mom in the US who's driving her kids to school all day going home, washing the dishes, doing the laundry but doesn't feel like there's much progress happening in her life. But then when she plays Candy Crush Saga she makes progress. She can see development.

She can see all these bright lights and positive reinforcement. And I also think that for some guys it's like there's a latent human desire for war to show that I'm special. And Battle Royale in particular and I agree with you in terms of the variability.

And there's been studies. I don't know if you guys are familiar with the Skinner box. What is the Skinner box?

So there was a research scientist named B.F. Skinner who did a study on rats that showed how can I get a rat to press this button more often even though there's an electric shock. And then they tried different kinds of ways to incentivize that rat to push the button. And what they found is that if you provided variable rewards then the rat will keep pushing that button forever.

And the way that Battle Royale is structured it's variable. And there's two other aspects. I remember hearing an interview with Ninja who said that the special thing about Battle Royale is that every Battle Royale is like a new story because of that variability aspect.

But the one other thing I would say is that on top of that plus I think that it speaks to Indian culture. Like I think that Indians have a latent desire to feel special. To feel like, yes I won Battle Royale.

I was the best out of 100 people. Is that a cultural thing where Indians feel differently from Americans? I think it's similar.

Actually the psychology is the same for Americans. Right? Because in America shooters are number one.

Battle Royale is number one. In the States as well. It's not true for Japan.

Japan RPGs are number one. For whatever reason. What are RPGs?

Role playing games. So they really love role playing games. More than shooters.

But in India and the US I think it's a similar psychology. Battle Royale and PUBG in particular has though is what I call a high climax moment. Meaning So there's like one definition of art and the definition of art that I ascribe to is that for me art is something that makes the user feel something.

So from that perspective that's what Battle Royale does really well.

[Speaker 1] (1:35:05 - 1:35:36)

What I believe inherently is all humans are permanently chasing status. Status in any way. I can be really moralistic about something.

Really altruistic. I can vie for sympathy with everything I can chase. Some kind of status.

So when we're talking about status in gaming do you think it's my skill being better than Sean for example which is giving me status? Or is it something more ulterior? Something below that?

[Speaker 2] (1:35:36 - 1:36:00)

I mean I think status can be gained in many ways. So for the kind of game if it's a shooter game that's like PUBG then it will be skill. So skill will differentiate you.

Now I mentioned that I used to work at a company called FunPlus and we worked on a 4X game. Which is more of a it's you march, you build up armies, you work with other people to defeat other people.

[Speaker 1] (1:36:01 - 1:36:03)

Like Age of Empires back in the day?

[Speaker 2] (1:36:04 - 1:36:14)

That's more of a PC 4X game. I think the most famous 4X game for mobile is called Game of War. And one of the things that we see in the 4X industry is like.

[Speaker 1] (1:36:15 - 1:36:16)

What does 4X stand for?

[Speaker 2] (1:36:17 - 1:37:00)

Explore I don't know. I don't even remember anymore. I don't know.

Exterminate something. Anyway there's 4Xs but one of the things that we used to talk about is like what would somebody pay to become famous? Like if you could be known by 30,000 people how valuable would that be to you?

What would you pay for that? Well guess what in 4X games people do pay it. So that they can be famous.

Famous in the social circle inside the game. You might be Locktar59 but and nobody in the real world knows who you are but in a specific game they might be like oh my god that's Locktar59 you know what I'm saying?

[Speaker 1] (1:37:01 - 1:37:08)

So what you're saying is like everything else in the world people inside games that are working are chasing status.

[Speaker 2] (1:37:09 - 1:37:24)

That could be one thing. They could be chasing emotion they could be chasing status, they could be chasing a feeling of progress and I think the different types of games help people cope with their latent human desires for something.

[Speaker 1] (1:37:25 - 1:37:45)

And is it very hard because of the opportunity cost? If I have spent X amount of time on a particular game derived Y amount of status is there a big moat because of that? I will not switch from that game to another because I'll have to rebuild status?

Is there a way to transition status from one game to another?

[Speaker 2] (1:37:46 - 1:37:59)

As far as I know not right now. I mean that was the I'm not sure how familiar you are with crypto games but that was like one of the things they were trying to do is to help transfer assets between games but that never really worked out yet.

[Speaker 1] (1:38:00 - 1:39:08)

As a gamer it did work out for me. I mean like if I look at, I had a very good following and people knew me 8BitThug in Clash Royale and it really helped me transition as a gamer, purely as a gamer transition well into PUBG Mobile in India and people still knew me and people would still want to join 8Bit because they knew me from that. But are you talking about your status in game or out of the game?

In game. Purely in game because that time it was all my friends within the game where people have never met. So I believe that it really helps but that's a gamer perspective.

It could be a unique case as well but it helps. So while I was researching today for today, the one thing that seemed to permeate every domain is games saw this crazy spike in COVID but right now the industry is completely screwed. People are getting fired in most large companies from Microsoft to Sony.

Games are getting dropped and it seems like a fairly tumultuous time for the industry today. How far is that true?

[Speaker 2] (1:39:09 - 1:39:38)

I actually don't think it's true. I don't know if you want to... Yes, because of COVID there was a huge spike but if you look at the overall trajectory, at least on the mobile side, the growth...

If you smooth out COVID then there was an overinvestment because of COVID and everyone was extrapolating linearly and a lot of additional people were hired and things like that. And now we're kind of correcting on the downside but that's a typical business cycle.

[Speaker 4] (1:39:39 - 1:39:41)

That is happening in every industry.

[Speaker 1] (1:39:42 - 1:39:45)

I know Nitish can't say anything about this because he's publicly listed.

[Speaker 3] (1:39:46 - 1:39:51)

He's going to say something. Actually answer this question every quarter.

[Speaker 1] (1:39:52 - 1:42:23)

But actually this happened with India as well. But tell me this. The money as a gamer that you made two years ago, has it gone down today?

Of course it has. That's what I'm saying. But it's a correction.

It's best for the industry. If this correction wouldn't have happened today, so a year earlier, around 2020, everyone was saying there's a bubble that's ready to burst in India first. But luckily it was not a bubble burst.

It was just a slight correction after all the global crisis that hit. And it's a correction. A correction for the good.

Because now, if I look at my side of the industry, esports team, owners, people entering the industry with the mindset of making quick money, you cannot make quick money anymore. So if you look at my company, when people were over-investing into their business, when their P&Ls were in red, deep red, I was spending the least. And today when the market is bad, you know, in a bad shape where there's not enough money flowing in, there's no streaming platform money, there's no direct money from the brands.

Everyone has tightened their grip. I'm spending the most and I've been able to sustain and grow. So I'm growing at a point.

So I think it all comes from the understanding of how people perceived about Indian gaming when they entered the market. What did they want to make? Quick buck because of the COVID, right?

Or they wanted to build something for the next 10, 15, 20 years. Like if they had some inspiration taken from somewhere from a team in America or a team in Europe, if a gamer entered the YouTube space to build something for the next 15 years or someone was looking for an overnight success because there were a lot of users flogging into YouTube to watch gaming. So I think that changed everything and the correction is for the best.

One thing I didn't ask you is your personal journey. Where do you make the most money from? Is it your content?

Is it the people you manage? I make the most money from people I manage. The talent management business.

Okay, when I look at establishing market size in India, the numbers state that gamers were 400 million in 21. In 23 they are 560 million going up every year. This doesn't sound reasonable to me.

Like India is a country where 2% of our population pays tax. Right? Like 25, 30 million people tops.

How are there 560 million gamers in India? I think this is RNG and SkillBased combined and I'm not sure because they would have more data. RNG, real money gaming?

Yeah. I think it's combined. This data, because we have 55 crore gamers I guess.

560 million. Impossible.

[Speaker 2] (1:42:25 - 1:43:02)

But I think everybody is a gamer, right? And one of the things that we haven't talked about is how because of some of the stuff that happened between the US and China, going back to that topic, a lot of production is shifting to India. There's going to be a Tesla factory in India.

There's all sorts of stuff moving to India, which should then enable a bigger middle class in India, which should then enable higher disposable income, which should then enable a lot of people in India to who maybe don't even identify as gamers to then spend in games because they actually are gamers. So what do you think?

[Speaker 1] (1:43:02 - 1:43:43)

Remove real money gaming. How many people in India are playing games on a Playstation or a computer versus how many people are playing on a mobile phone and how many people are doing real money gaming? If we had to break that down.

Some of them, right? I think 95% 95% 95% what? Mobile.

Yeah, yeah. Mobile games. And BGMI being the largest.

Mobile games? Could be. But there could be a casual game like taking space.

But I think the highest grossing app 97% of what? Not 550 million.

[Speaker 4] (1:43:44 - 1:43:49)

95%, 97 5% of the whole gaming population.

[Speaker 1] (1:43:49 - 1:43:54)

Sean can tell us. He'll know the numbers since he's a market leader. How many people are playing BGMI in India?

[Speaker 4] (1:43:55 - 1:44:33)

I believe like people who are actually regularly playing one specific, one or two specific games and at least willing to pay. Maybe they haven't paid at all or they might pay once in like maybe 3, 5, 6 months. Which has capacity to pay or willingness to pay altogether.

Might be I believe 100 million or 80 million ish. That's a lot. That's still a lot.

Maybe the average payment average paying amount might be much lesser than global average. But at least they are willing to pay for gaming.

[Speaker 1] (1:44:33 - 1:45:03)

The way I look at this space is for content. Netflix, maybe 6, 7 million people are willing to pay the $10. It peaks at Jio Cinemas, Hotstar, Combination.

Maybe 50 million people are willing to pay $10 a year for crazy amount of content. So if that is 50 million but 100 million are willing to pay to play, it's a lot. And you're talking more in-app

purchases, right?

[Speaker 4] (1:45:04 - 1:45:05)

Not pay to play.

[Speaker 1] (1:45:06 - 1:45:06)

Yeah.

[Speaker 4] (1:45:07 - 1:45:17)

I mean, there is no very good statistics from one source. It's more of guesstimation. But that's my guesstimation.

[Speaker 1] (1:45:17 - 1:45:20)

And real money gaming, do you agree with that number?

[Speaker 3] (1:45:20 - 1:45:35)

Yeah, I think so. I think the important point to also understand is there's a perception that games in India are played by kids or youngsters. But I think that's not true at all.

Now, and especially after COVID, it's cutting across demographics, ages, genders.

[Speaker 1] (1:45:35 - 1:45:43)

I read a stat that youngsters are spending 12 hours a day, 12 hours a week on gaming. But I'm guessing adults can't be spending that much.

[Speaker 3] (1:45:43 - 1:46:03)

No, they are. And different use cases for different people. You know, my own grandmom just touched 90.

And she plays games on her phone. And she likes to play word games for a variety of entertainment, right? When we were going IPO, one of the things on my mind was responsible gaming.

We have a game called World Cricket Championship which is a popular cricket game.

[Speaker 1] (1:46:04 - 1:46:11)

Don't virtue signal because you're a listed company and talk about responsible gaming. You wish your clients were playing 24 hours a day.

[Speaker 3] (1:46:11 - 1:46:14)

No, no, but still I had to look at it.

[Speaker 1] (1:46:15 - 1:46:35)

You're selling a game at the end of the day, right? Another stat I wanted to ask is I read that in the gaming split while we were establishing market size. First thing, Sean said 100 million.

Let's go with that number. I'm assuming of the balance 450, a lot of it is real money gaming?

[Speaker 3] (1:46:36 - 1:46:59)

No, because 100 million, he said, are potential payers. There are a lot of casual gamers, right? Who are not playing.

Yeah, a lot of people. And all, again as I said, across demographics. Playing for time pass.

Word games, cooking games, sports games. And they're happy to see some ads and continue playing.

[Speaker 1] (1:46:59 - 1:47:33)

And how big is Dream11? What is their number of users count? I think it's over 200 million.

Yeah, that kind of starting to add up, right? 200 from there, 100 from here. The balance 115 casual.

And people say that the split is 60 men, 40 women. Is that right? I'll talk about my industry.

In finance the split is more like 83 men and 17 women. Participants. Is it really 60-40?

I think it's 75-25-ish. It's from what I read, latest.

[Speaker 4] (1:47:33 - 1:47:49)

So maybe mid-core-ish games, which is more like, which needs more time spend and more focus. That would 75 male and 25 female. I think casual games, it can become more balanced.

[Speaker 1] (1:47:49 - 1:49:54)

Do you guys have an opinion on real money gaming? I'm sure you heard about the taxation in India. I'll go through each one of you because it's such a big monster in the room that we have to talk about it, right?

Like while I see this, Harsh is a really good friend of mine, the Dream11 guy. I think he's Nitish's

friend as well. But how do you think it affects Dream11 and all of his competitors?

Do you think it's fair that they did what they did? Let's start with Animesh. I don't think it's fair.

I think it was too harsh. It was too harsh to Harsh. Too harsh to Harsh.

But I felt that it was more harsh on the profitability from my layman understanding. Because I saw that Dream11 did put out a coupon code in a way, you know, it did not affect the end user at the end. So I think smart plays always come into play.

But yeah, I guess it did take a hit. I had good friends in MPL and Winzo who were really affected. I met the Winzo co-founders a couple of times and they've been very good clients.

So has been MPL. People were really hit hard. So I actually pity for the industry because that was like a one night thing.

It just suddenly changed everything for them. But yeah, I think the government has a big team working on them. So they always take the best decision.

I'm all for free market capitalism. I feel like if somebody is willing to engage with a certain platform consciously, somebody able, willing, adult, spending his own money, I feel like regulation skews industries in manners which is not always conducive to innovation and evolution of whatever industry. I feel like there should be less control and not more.

Nitish, this is a more nuanced question for you because I know Nazara doesn't really do RMG but you have a tiny component which is like 1% or 2%. What do you think?

[Speaker 3] (1:49:55 - 1:50:17)

I think over the last few years it's clearly been demonstrated that the consumer demand is there. Consumer interest in participating and playing real money games is definitely very high in India. It's not new, right?

People participating and betting in cricket has forever been there. It's not even allowed, it's banned.

[Speaker 1] (1:50:17 - 1:50:25)

Would you argue that it formalized what was otherwise a black market where we as Indians were not benefiting from the tax revenue?

[Speaker 3] (1:50:25 - 1:50:27)

Yeah, absolutely.

[Speaker 1] (1:50:27 - 1:50:43)

What do you think about it personally? If I were to ask you about fantasy fantasy cricket, rummy, poker, a whole bunch of games like that, which game requires the most skill to least skill in that order?

[Speaker 3] (1:50:44 - 1:51:47)

I think it's not necessarily the game but how it is played and who is playing it, whether it is for skill or not, right? But my overall thesis here is that there is consumer demand. People are going to play.

When you ban, you've seen in many states, for example in India, where games have been banned. The online real money games have been banned. The business has usually gone underground to more irresponsible players, which completely exposes the users.

So I think the right balance with the right amount of regulation and framework for companies to responsibly do it as well as the government to get its fair share of tax is probably a healthier place to be versus a completely unregulated market which is going underground and getting screwed up. Now in terms of what is the tax, what is the fair amount of tax, I think there is no perfect answer.

[Speaker 1] (1:51:48 - 1:51:50)

Currently, what was the number? 30%?

[Speaker 3] (1:51:52 - 1:52:12)

28% Now the latest tax on the GST is 28% on deposits. Earlier, gaming companies were paying 18% on their rake. Now the spectrum can be very large.

It could be 18% on rake. It could be all the way 28% on entry fee.

[Speaker 1] (1:52:12 - 1:52:14)

Is the tax now on rake or the money?

[Speaker 3] (1:52:14 - 1:52:18)

It's on the money you deposit. If you put in 100 rupees in your online wallet.

[Speaker 1] (1:52:18 - 1:52:22)

Do you think that is the part people are contesting? That it should be on the rake and not the money put in?

[Speaker 3] (1:52:23 - 1:52:28)

Yeah. I mean the industry is of course I mean they would want the least amount of tax, right?

[Speaker 1] (1:52:28 - 1:52:37)

So that is the main contention. It is okay to charge the revenue of the company but like in e-commerce terms, not the GMB.

[Speaker 3] (1:52:37 - 1:52:45)

Yeah. So that's where it is right now. But I think over the next few months, hopefully there will be more clarity on how this pans out.

[Speaker 1] (1:53:06 - 1:53:34)

I want each of you guys to come up with one thing. What is it that will be relevant 5 years from now? Raise your guess.

You want to go first? I think that person needs to realize that attention span has already declined. It's gonna decline further.

So whatever they are making, it needs to move at a very fast speed for the user. So you both are in contradiction there because Joseph thinks casual and super casual which might require lesser attention span is declining.

[Speaker 2] (1:53:35 - 1:53:44)

Well hyper casual is declining. I would say casual is not necessarily declining but hyper casual in terms of these very casual games with a bunch of ads for reasons.

[Speaker 1] (1:53:45 - 1:53:47)

In my mind I think snake is hyper casual.

[Speaker 2] (1:53:48 - 1:53:54)

Think snake but they load a bunch of ads on top of it. So that stuff is starting to go away.

[Speaker 1] (1:53:54 - 1:57:10)

So what do you mean by your time focused on the game going down? How much time? I think it's not about the time, it's about the next event that's gonna happen when I'm playing the game.

So I think if I, for example, if I'm meeting an NPC, a non-playing character in the game and it progresses my storyline. Earlier when I've played games like Batman, etc, we used to have long chats, long dialogues that they used to tell. The story used to be really beautiful.

I don't think people are gonna be ready for that in the next five years. The first event, the next event needs the rate at which events happen in the game or events occur in the game needs to be faster. Because I think swipe up generation is gonna take up the world and it's just gonna be swipe, swipe, swipe.

So we need to have events that happen faster, attention span games that are fast paced, very fast paced. I think that's the reason maybe Battle Royale or FPS games would live longer. Because it always involves action.

Like you know, even if you're standing at a position, you're still doing something which will help the next event occur. But when you're playing story mode games or normal casual games, you cannot just be moving slowly and wait for something to happen. Give me an example of the kind of game which will work in five years and one which won't.

I think there's a game called Among Us. It should still work in five years. And that works in five years because something is happening.

Because something is happening really fast. I believe that we cannot have those slow story mode games that we used to play. Same thing we established why watching movies and sport is not working anymore because you're not interacting with the interface in a manner.

You're watching and it takes a long period of time. Also, I think it could be a major reason why TikTok and Reels and Shorts are doing really well. Last night, I was actually scrolling your podcast Shorts and it literally took me into a loop of two and a half hours where I just got related content.

I got so intrigued. Then I was looking at your guests, speaking at some other places. Then I dipped down into Ritesh's other interviews.

So it's just a loop. And I just saw the 3am and I was like, good two and a half hours but that is what it is about. But I won't watch a two and a half hours of a movie, of a content of a related topic.

And one example of a game which won't work in five years? A very beautiful game that I used to play. Not able to recollect its name.

But something like I would say a Batman Arkham Knight wouldn't work. It's one of a very fantastic game. I think it's slow paced because you know you have those dialogues coming in.

You have to go from one place to another. The movements are difficult. I think even if you talk about the way the movements happen in the game.

People would want more simplified versions of it. Like you know, just give us two buttons, two joysticks, allow us to move. Like even me, I'm playing less games nowadays because I have

other work to do.

But when now I want to play new games, I tend to play simpler games. Which do not have too many abilities, too many buttons that I need to use. So maybe I think there could be a transition.

I believe that there are a lot of people like me who are transitioning into such type of games. These are a few things that might change five years later. And Nitesh, one insight five years from now that people should bear in mind looking to build a career here?

[Speaker 3] (1:57:10 - 1:58:09)

I think gaming is on the cusp of many new technologies. And therefore the experience of gaming itself is changing. We already spoke a lot about AI, so I won't repeat that.

But also for example, I'm personally of the opinion that virtual reality will become far more tangible in the years to come. And I've been playing with the Apple Vision Pro and the Quest Pro. And I think now the experience we've been looking at for a decade I think.

The company we've been looking at VR for a decade. It was never there. I think the experience has got there and I think once it transcends a little bit more maybe two, three years down now you have three big players.

Sony, Meta and now Apple in that fray. I think you will go from potentially playing a game to being in the game, which can be transformative. I know that a lot of people are still very pessimistic because I think they're burned for very long on VR and stuff like that.

But at least I believe that's the future of gaming.

[Speaker 1] (1:58:09 - 1:58:17)

How does somebody build the proficiency required to cater to games on VR and AR?

[Speaker 3] (1:58:18 - 1:58:23)

I mean it's the same tools that you're using largely. Is it like a completely different thing?

[Speaker 2] (1:58:23 - 1:58:27)

Building a game for VR? You can use some of the same engines.

[Speaker 3] (1:58:27 - 1:58:29)

Engines are similar.

[Speaker 2] (1:58:31 - 1:58:32)

Sean?

[Speaker 4] (1:58:35 - 1:59:48)

Nitish mentioned about AR. I mean VR. So I would I feel that AR might be closer than VR.

I mean I also bought a different version of MetaQuest. Which I used maybe for two, three hours. Maybe one week or two weeks.

And then I gave up. Why? Because it doesn't feel very comfortable to play long hours.

And that uncomfortableness doesn't sort of allow me to re-engage. But I think AR, for example, like Pokemon Go, which blend the physical space with your smartphone, actually gives a lot of different experience which traditional games didn't offer. I think that can be actually invented in a lot of different ways.

If you, as a game designer or a game producer, if you can really become innovative and experimental. So that is my sort of...

[Speaker 1] (1:59:48 - 2:01:15)

What is the role of Discord and Twitch in the gaming world? Yeah, so Discord was more of the chatroom that used to exist when games did not have VOIP, like you could not talk within the game. There used to be Teamspeak, a software called Teamspeak, then Discord took over.

However, Discord also brought with itself the community building angle in the form of a server. It's called a Discord server. So what you could do is you could get your friends or people only whom you want to join inside a particular server and do a closed chat and a closed call outside the game.

So I think Discord really changed everything for gaming in a lot of ways, but now Discord has gone into a lot of things, like it's relevant to a lot of industries. Relevant to a lot of industries that are non-gaming, that are into... It's a big space for Web3 also.

I think a lot of Web3 games are being discussed and the communities are being formed within Discord. It's great for art as well. I have joined some servers which used to have artists in it who used to help me out.

So it's a good community building. It's a social media platform, I would say. Is it a good way...

Somebody said Discord is democratizing game marketing. I don't think Discord has too much of a role to play in that, but I would let them take this question. Like, if a game is really good, people will chat with each other in the gaming community in Discord, discover it.

So traditional marketing for games might be getting disrupted.

[Speaker 2] (2:01:16 - 2:02:15)

I would actually think that it's more... Rather than Discord, it's more Twitch and YouTube that are allowing influencers to become the new marketing for games. Today, you mentioned Among Us, but some of those games were going nowhere for like...

I think Among Us had nothing for like three or four years, and then some influencers picked it up and talked about it, and then it blew up. So I would agree where Discord is more of like the community tool, the ways that you can have a one-on-one conversation with your players and your audience to get that direct feedback. So I view it more as a feedback and community building mechanism.

We think in similar ways on that. But I think that in terms of marketing, that would be more Twitch and YouTube. And certainly, that has been a big shift, is that influencers now are really driving many installs and driving a lot of the word of mouth and awareness for games today.

[Speaker 1] (2:02:15 - 2:04:26)

If I had a game, I did all that we discussed. I did Nvidia's free course. I did the University of Michigan free course.

I learned whatever Roblox is. And then I built not a hyper-casual but a casual game, which is mobile first, because most people in India are playing on mobile. You said 97%.

Do I then integrate influencers, Discord and Twitch to sell the game and get the word out? Is there a particular way to do that? How does a game garner virality?

See, that's a very typical way of doing it. You're launching a product in the market and you have influencers talking about it. The other way of how me as a gamer want things to happen is involve those influencers or those key stakeholders or those gamers that you actually want to target.

Obviously, it cannot be the entire cohort, but at your alpha or pre-beta stage or even before alpha. So this is one thing that Indus did, the super gaming that I'm talking about. Indus invited us a year and a half back to just show us the game.

Just take casual feedback of how it's doing, what do you think about it. I think those are some key things that are very important. It really helped strike a chord between me and Mortal who went there.

If they invited us at such a stage to take feedback, that means it's a sort of a moral responsibility towards us that when this game comes out, we'll talk about it. And we actually went there and talked about it. Even today we talk about it.

That's the reason I'm talking about it because I felt really connected to it. So I believe that

generally the development story also helps. That was the case with how Riot does it.

They will call the game Project X. Then they'll talk about it for two years. Then they will release teasers.

Then there will be leaks that will come out. And then they will release a game with alpha, beta, pre-beta and an official launch. So I think a good way to go about is talk about it, start very early.

If your product is ready and then you want to launch it, it's always very expensive. I mean like, you know, the marketing starts very early.

[Speaker 3] (2:04:27 - 2:05:02)

So this is external marketing. You can also build virality into your game. So one is if you can play the game with your friends.

Right? For example, in India, Ludo blew up because when I was playing Ludo, I wanted to play it with my friends. And I would automatically through the game easily be able to invite my friends or family to play with me, right?

Many games incorporate stuff like you can unlock special features if you refer this game to five friends. A lot of hacks that you can build into your game also to drive organic virality from within your game.

[Speaker 1] (2:05:04 - 2:05:15)

If I know nothing about the gaming world and I want to go talk to people who are in the gaming world, where is the easiest place to connect with them? I'm starting from scratch.

[Speaker 2] (2:05:16 - 2:05:22)

In India, probably IGDC, the game conference. When does it happen?

[Speaker 1] (2:05:22 - 2:05:23)

Who organizes it?

[Speaker 2] (2:05:24 - 2:05:24)

November.

[Speaker 4] (2:05:25 - 2:05:26)

Hyderabad.

[Speaker 1] (2:05:28 - 2:05:29)

Who puts it on?

[Speaker 4] (2:05:29 - 2:05:29)

Sorry?

[Speaker 1] (2:05:30 - 2:05:31)

Who organizes it?

[Speaker 4] (2:05:32 - 2:05:40)

It's a volunteer organization. There's a committee or council members. Who has been in the industry for a long time?

[Speaker 1] (2:05:41 - 2:06:51)

I think the Indian typical mind would work differently. If I want to know about something, I would search who the most famous person is and try to figure out where that person is doing a dialogue. And then reach that.

I think majority of the Indians would first come to a gamer who is streaming on YouTube or Twitch, go to his chat, speak and then start. IGDC, believe me, no 19-year-old boy who knows nothing about gaming would never enter IGDC. He would never enter.

But maybe a good idea for him too? Yeah. On the other side, it's a great idea.

Obviously, IGDC I think is the biggest gaming industry event that happens. What are some other topics that you guys think are relevant that I might not know about? Why?

For me, it's very relevant. I actually want Sean and Joseph to answer about it. Why is that only BGMI and Free Fire were able to do so big?

CODM failed. A lot of other games came to India, tried for 2-3 months and failed. And why is it only BGMI and Free Fire on mobile games?

The reason why I'm asking is because I don't have an answer for this except for the fact that I praise you guys a lot that the publisher took keen interest in the country. You guys set up the esports ecosystem and everything else. This is one thing everyone would want to know.

[Speaker 4] (2:06:51 - 2:08:58)

I think Joseph might be the best person to answer this question from the developer perspective. I'm not, myself, I'm not a developer. But let me just start, as an appetizer he will serve main dish.

So, from my point of view, this size of a success, and I believe the Battle Royale game has

opened up India's gaming industry into a different direction compared to what had existed before that. It actually happens not very often and it doesn't really happen with a lot of intention. It happens very luckily or very coincidentally.

I think it could happen because of definitely 4G penetration was there. And then there was no other genre or game which has that sort of reach before Battle Royale. And also Battle Royale game, not on just mobile, and console and PC, it has opened up shooter game into different sort of expanded appeal.

So that actually coincident coincide in that time period. And also after two years, COVID happened, which also amplified that sort of trends. So I wanted to emphasize in a slightly different manner for this because I feel that if India wants to become a powerhouse in gaming, especially game development perspective, I think young people in India should try many games and try to make their own games.

I haven't seen many game developers who become very successful in the first title. I think even 19-year-old boy on the Roblox, he might have made 5, 10 different games. And then maybe it's 11th game or 15th games.

So I think you should not try to become perfect to start something. You should try something original on your own, even if you feel not ready.

[Speaker 1] (2:08:59 - 2:09:22)

So I have a question for you. You launched BGMI in India. You did RTV.

You have done Bullet Eco two days ago. The spends that you are doing towards popularizing the game or making the esports for that particular title popular, will it be even like... What percentage would you allot to RTV or Bullet Eco compared to BGMI?

Explain RTV, Bullet Eco. It's a game.

[Speaker 4] (2:09:22 - 2:09:24)

It's a strategy.

[Speaker 1] (2:09:24 - 2:09:51)

And it took off really well. And even I was playing it and then interest fell off. Because interest fell off for me and a lot of other creators because we saw that the esports ecosystem is not building as great as you guys are doing for BGMI.

Because this is like the gamer within me asking you how do you guys go about it? And then why someone should build every other game if a company as big as Crafted is not trying to build every game with equal interest.

[Speaker 4] (2:09:52 - 2:10:53)

That's a very good and tricky question to answer. But I will be just bold enough to answer, give some answers. I feel that I think you can try to make certain games to be esports compatible when you first design the game.

But when you launch the game, either it's a soft launch or commercial launch, you find a lot of gap between what you actually felt it would work and actually it didn't work. I think in case of Road to Valor, I think we felt that feeling. You design certain things like one versus one would be fun, and fun to play and fun to watch.

It was fun to play in a way, but not so fun to watch to be honest. So we added recently like two versus two. We changed the UI for people to naturally come into two versus two more dynamic and social experience.

But maybe the timing wise it's a little late, maybe.

[Speaker 1] (2:10:54 - 2:11:00)

That's a very interesting insight. So games today to work have to be fun to play, but also fun to watch?

[Speaker 4] (2:11:01 - 2:11:02)

Yeah, that's where my business is built.

[Speaker 1] (2:11:04 - 2:11:06)

Anything else that you guys think is relevant, Nitesh?

[Speaker 3] (2:11:07 - 2:12:39)

I just want to add a couple of points which I think are very important for our young Indian developers. One is that they need to iterate and ship fast. Because if you start a game as a young developer with a plan that I'll ship it in 18 months and 24 months, they run out of money, it doesn't happen, right?

And they lose confidence. So I think initially at least they need to take on games and projects which are shippable fast, and then they can get their MVP out or the minimum viable product out, and then look at the data and iterate it. And if the data is a disaster, then maybe give it one or two shots and move on to the next project.

I'm seeing a lot of developers get stuck in this loop otherwise, if they're not shipping out. And that's a big failure for many of them. So I just want to highlight that.

I think the second thing is it's very important that they focus on the right metrics. I often say it's important for them to focus on the real metrics versus the vanity metrics early on. Just to give an example of what I mean, usually when a developer comes to me and says I have 50,000 downloads of my game.

To me, immediately that's largely a vanity metric. I don't react much to that because I'm being honest. The downloads may mean nothing.

But if the developer comes and tells me my D1 retention is 40%, my D7 retention is 20%.

[Speaker 1] (2:12:39 - 2:12:40)

D7 being?

[Speaker 3] (2:12:40 - 2:12:48)

D7. The retention of these. Suddenly my eyes will start lighting up, right?

As we're telling my BD team, okay, meet this developer.

[Speaker 1] (2:12:48 - 2:12:52)

Do you have a mechanism where young people can come pitch your games to all of you guys?

[Speaker 3] (2:12:52 - 2:13:08)

Yeah, absolutely. So we launched something called Nazara Publishing now which is actually meant to help developers because we really believe that making India is a big opportunity for Indian developers. For India and for the world, right?

So we of course have to have that and we do have that.

[Speaker 1] (2:13:08 - 2:13:11)

So how does someone pitch Nazara Publishing?

[Speaker 3] (2:13:11 - 2:13:15)

They come to publishing.nazara.com and fill in an application form.

[Speaker 1] (2:13:16 - 2:13:18)

Nice. Do you guys have that too at Craftin?

[Speaker 4] (2:13:19 - 2:13:23)

Yeah, we do. I mean they are more like a pure core.

[Speaker 2] (2:13:23 - 2:13:26)

We're focused on building one or two games.

[Speaker 4] (2:13:26 - 2:13:27)

We can't make anything else.

[Speaker 1] (2:13:28 - 2:13:36)

What is the biggest hurdle you're facing in building the game that you are writing? Talent. Because you're in India?

[Speaker 2] (2:13:37 - 2:13:53)

Yes, talent and I touched upon this before, right? Because there are so many people who leave India and it's hard to argue for someone who wants to live in another country, who wants to make dramatically more money. Why would you want to stay in India?

[Speaker 1] (2:13:55 - 2:14:01)

But if the games are going to compete in the same market, one could argue that you could pay them the same amount of money?

[Speaker 2] (2:14:02 - 2:15:33)

Once we're profitable, sure. And I think that in some industries like to some degree that's starting to happen. So we've seen a pretty fast acceleration in the compensation of engineers over the past four or five years as the world became more remote.

Certainly after COVID, I think engineers got paid dramatically more, right? So we're starting to see some of that impact as well. But one thing I would want young people to think about really try to start with what do you want from your life?

I think that's a question that not enough young people have asked themselves. And I think that some people have bought into these notions of the popularized notions of quiet quitting, side hustle, things like that. And I just think that if more people really thought critically about what they're really searching for their life, that they'd be able to make better decisions about the path that they would choose.

And there's an exercise actually, I believe it was Clayton Christensen who wrote about an exercise that he recommended for people, which is to think about your life when you're on your deathbed and thinking back and what would make you proud. How would you measure the value of your life looking back? I think not enough young people do that.

And I think that that's something that as an older guy who didn't think about that for way too much of my life, I wish I had.

[Speaker 1] (2:15:34 - 2:15:49)

I want to highlight or pick five most relevant skill sets required to build a career in gaming. Each one of you can tell me one. What do we start with?

You mentioned art earlier.

[Speaker 2] (2:15:50 - 2:15:51)

Oh, you mean the disciplines?

[Speaker 5] (2:15:52 - 2:15:52)

Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (2:15:52 - 2:16:07)

So there's probably four main disciplines. There's art, engineering, or development. Third is product management or production.

And fourth is design.

[Speaker 3] (2:16:07 - 2:16:23)

Design. And fifth is, if I can go with the fifth is I think which is very important is also your data analytics. Data analytics.

Being able to understand data and react to data is very important.

[Speaker 1] (2:16:24 - 2:16:28)

Okay. So what does somebody need to build a career in art in the gaming world?

[Speaker 2] (2:16:30 - 2:17:00)

I mean get the necessary skills. Also there's a big difference between 2D and 3D art. There's a difference between doing concept art versus production art.

There's a lot of nuance there within art. Let's say there's 3D art, there's 2D art. And then within that there's also are you focused on characters?

Are you focused on environment?

[Speaker 1] (2:17:00 - 2:17:22)

Okay. And how does somebody learn how to make 2D art, 3D art, character? Usually there's schools for that.

For example? I don't know the name of the schools in India. Something like an animation or something.

And how much does somebody working in the art side of gaming make as a starting pay? Not much.

[Speaker 5] (2:17:22 - 2:17:24)

Art is lower side.

[Speaker 1] (2:17:25 - 2:17:30)

But depends who the consumer is. But lower side is how much? In India?

[Speaker 2] (2:17:31 - 2:17:36)

I would say the very lowest I've seen is like 5 lakhs or less.

[Speaker 4] (2:17:37 - 2:17:40)

Entry level. We're talking entry level.

[Speaker 1] (2:17:40 - 2:17:51)

5 lakhs a year. And you also mentioned Joseph and Nitish actually that AI might make this entire section redundant very fast. It might be.

[Speaker 4] (2:17:52 - 2:18:05)

Lower or middle level. Maybe very senior or maybe someone who can make some direction. Maybe they.

But then they can be replaced by some game designer.

[Speaker 2] (2:18:06 - 2:18:36)

I don't know if you guys have checked out sona.ai. But if you haven't, you absolutely should. You just give it some descriptions and it'll automatically create music. And you can see that where that is today in two to three years.

We could be living in a world where most of the music we hear is AI generated rather than generated by human beings. Similarly for art, we're kind of getting to a place where you can kind of describe things and then just many variations just kind of pop up.

[Speaker 1] (2:18:38 - 2:18:41)

You wouldn't recommend if you had a 14 year old child, you wouldn't say.

[Speaker 2] (2:18:41 - 2:18:59)

If I'm thinking macro, I would be like, art. I'd probably unless you really had a very specific skill. Because I think ultimately masters at their craft are masters at their craft.

But otherwise, I would probably avoid it.

[Speaker 1] (2:18:59 - 2:19:01)

So you're swimming against the tide in art.

[Speaker 2] (2:19:01 - 2:19:42)

Yes, and maybe in engineering too because. What does the engineering breakdown look like? I would say there's more of a linear path in engineering.

I would say, except for you're generally thinking in terms of front-end versus back-end. In the front-end, you're generally going to be working with one of the two primary game engines, Unity or Unreal. You would learn either C Sharp or C++ depending on which engine you use.

Then for back-end, the front-end means the thing you actually play. The combat, the characters that move around, all the functionality.

[Speaker 5] (2:19:42 - 2:19:43)

Like the UI in a way.

[Speaker 2] (2:19:43 - 2:20:05)

All that stuff. That's included there. Then the back-end is like when you're saving your stats to the back-end server.

The net code so that you can play against other players. All the stuff you don't see but makes the game operate in the back-end. Generally speaking, you have engineers oriented around one of those two, either front-end or back-end.

But you also have some full-stat guys.

[Speaker 1] (2:20:05 - 2:20:10)

So you would go C Sharp, learn how to use Unity, Unreal, and become really proficient at that?

[Speaker 2] (2:20:10 - 2:20:29)

Yeah, I would probably recommend for India for right now, Unity, C Sharp. But later, I would recommend C++, Unreal. Unreal is starting to take over.

But in the long-term, if current trends continue, Unreal is likely the engine of choice in the not-too-distant future.

[Speaker 1] (2:20:30 - 2:20:34)

Nice. And how much would somebody in engineering make on average, front-end, back-end?

[Speaker 2] (2:20:34 - 2:20:48)

I'm guessing they're very different. That depends on the school. Right?

So if you go to IIT and you come out, you can make 40-50 lakhs. With no experience? With no experience.

It's possible, yeah.

[Speaker 4] (2:20:48 - 2:20:50)

Assuming that you will catch up very fast.

[Speaker 1] (2:20:51 - 2:21:18)

And also assuming that you will actually get hired. But he's saying they're lacking talent. They're looking for people that Actually, I see a lot of job openings on LinkedIn from the popular developers or publishers.

I don't see any opening for a newbie into the industry. Really? Yes.

I might be wrong here. But from the openings that I've tried to go by, I don't think big studios are hiring people who are freshers. The small guys.

Well, we still do. We still hire freshers.

[Speaker 4] (2:21:19 - 2:21:33)

We also try to hire experienced guys. But then it didn't work out that very well. And then there is some gap.

We expect this level of experience, but they don't So we have to change the direction.

[Speaker 2] (2:21:33 - 2:21:43)

On the engineering side, though, there's a big gap, right? We generally don't like to hire from IT just because there's such a huge premium for those guys. But yeah, it can come down quite a bit.

[Speaker 1] (2:21:43 - 2:21:55)

Is there a way somebody who does engineering learns Unity, Unreal, C Sharp, C++ can get experience without having a full-time job, internship opportunities?

[Speaker 2] (2:21:56 - 2:22:33)

They build their own projects, publish them, submit them to GitHub. So yeah, there's a lot of ways where you can distinguish yourself as a good engineer if you wanted to. But also, I think the thing that's missing for most of the people that I've interviewed in India for game development, unlike other places, is just hardcore math and logic skills.

That's something that is critical as an engineer, but seems to be lacking quite a lot. Even from the IIT crowd? No, the IIT guys are fine.

[Speaker 1] (2:22:36 - 2:22:38)

Do you hire from the same place?

[Speaker 3] (2:22:39 - 2:22:50)

Yeah, but we have a very distributed way of working. So we have different studios that we own, and each have their own different policies of how they are recruiting. It's not very centralized.

[Speaker 2] (2:22:53 - 2:24:35)

Production, product management? Yeah, so product management is, I would say, a pretty difficult skill to learn on your own. In my opinion, it requires hands-on practice.

But there are a number of online resources. We provide some resources as well that teach about product management. I can share some of those links.

Would it typically be an engineering guy upgrading or getting promoted to be a product manager? Not necessarily. Not usually, but I will say that in our product team at Leela, two of our product managers we hired from engineering.

And similar to Sean's case, what I have realized is that in our case too, we prefer to hire people who are new, but hungry and wanting to learn versus people who have worked at an existing game company in India for four to five years. Because I kind of touched upon this before, live services and live operating a game, that set of skills is very different. It's the difference between 0 to 1 versus 1 to N.

What is the skill? The skill in terms of new game development is so different from live operations where everything's kind of figured out. It's like, I'm just following the normal playbook.

I think in new game development, you have to be kind of brutal, very effective. The communication style, there's a whole difference in culture and mentality for new game development versus live operations.

[Speaker 1] (2:24:36 - 2:24:42)

Does it also equate to the nuance of skill, building for skill? Is that the product manager's role?

[Speaker 2] (2:24:42 - 2:25:16)

Well, I think it's building for product market fit relative to 1 to N where you are building for larger scale. And I'm assuming these guys get paid the most, right? I would say engineers right now get paid the most.

More than product managers. Yes. So this would be the second most.

30 lakhs, 20 lakhs. Starting off it's less. I think starting off product managers, I mean, again, it depends on the school, but I mean, starting product managers would make 10 lakhs or less.

You guys know the numbers better than I do.

[Speaker 4] (2:25:16 - 2:25:35)

I agree. Like product manager in the junior level, they don't make too much difference. So their entry salary would be lower.

Slightly higher than artists. But I think if they go to the producer, like we are the main producer level, then their salary can be as equal as engineers.

[Speaker 2] (2:25:35 - 2:25:37)

On the higher end.

[Speaker 4] (2:25:37 - 2:25:38)

On the higher end.

[Speaker 2] (2:25:38 - 2:25:38)

And the design?

[Speaker 1] (2:25:40 - 2:25:44)

Design, so I would have assumed art and design are very similar, no?

[Speaker 4] (2:25:44 - 2:25:47)

It's not like art design. It's more like game design.

[Speaker 2] (2:25:48 - 2:25:53)

Now, I would say that design is the weakest area in India.

[Speaker 5] (2:25:53 - 2:25:53)

Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (2:25:54 - 2:25:58)

So finding a good designer, I don't even know where you go to learn that. Why is that?

[Speaker 3] (2:26:02 - 2:26:35)

I don't know. No, no. It's because traditionally in India, animation, art has always been an industry.

Right? Even job work for just animation. Forget gaming.

Similarly, coding across industries has always been there. But design specifically for a game, which requires how do you make a game that is engaging, right? How do you get the user in that flow state?

I think that thinking, it comes naturally when you are really exposed to it over a very long period of time.

[Speaker 1] (2:26:35 - 2:26:45)

So if I am a designer, a game designer, I will pick when to shoot, when the real characters come in, when the static characters go out, stuff like that.

[Speaker 3] (2:26:46 - 2:26:47)

It's the gameplay.

[Speaker 1] (2:26:48 - 2:26:51)

It's not design as much as figuring the flow.

[Speaker 2] (2:26:51 - 2:27:39)

It's complex. It's complicated because there's actually like, I would probably characterize game design in two parts. One is gameplay, which is like for any kind of, the way you typically think about a game, for a snake, what do you do?

What are the actions? What are the specific things happening? And then the second part of design is systems design.

You mentioned meta, right? And so the meta or systems part is like the progression, compulsion part, where you might have a crafting system. You might be building a house.

It's not the main gameplay. You might play the game, earn some stuff, and then go craft something somewhere else. But these two are generally separate.

And generally, like someone great at gameplay design, in terms of the combat, feel of the gun, things like that, is often different from the person who is designing the systems.

[Speaker 4] (2:27:40 - 2:28:06)

I would say the game design requires creativity most, among all other disciplines. And then it can be generally taught through some kind of apprenticeship, but it also requires kind of natural born or educated creativity. So which if you don't have that culture of bringing up those talents, then it might not come out easily.

[Speaker 2] (2:28:07 - 2:28:12)

I actually think Indians could be great at design. They just need the proper educational resources.

[Speaker 4] (2:28:13 - 2:28:26)

Yeah, the bridging that sort of the creativity in their culture and in their brain, and make it, transforming it into the more professional or practical level. That actually is difficult to happen, actually.

[Speaker 2] (2:28:27 - 2:29:26)

And where can an Indian learn that, a 20-year-old? They can start by designing for Roblox, for example, on the UGC platforms. But I guess one of the drawbacks for India is because, like, most of the people I know building for Roblox, they don't do it on their phone.

They do it on a PC, and because there aren't a lot of homes with PCs, that may be one of the things holding India back. Why don't they do it on their phone? It's just too difficult, right?

And then if you're coding, like in Lua, I mean, you don't want to be doing that on your phone. But that's different in the West? People are...

Almost every home has PCs in their house, as well as, you know, tablets and other things. But, I mean, similar for China, there aren't... I mean, there are some places that have...

I think there's PC penetration is probably higher in China, but still not as abundant as, like, US and other places. How much does a game designer make?

[Speaker 4] (2:29:28 - 2:29:28)

The most?

[Speaker 2] (2:29:28 - 2:29:28)

An artist.

[Speaker 4] (2:29:30 - 2:29:31)

It varies a lot.

[Speaker 2] (2:29:31 - 2:29:47)

Yeah, it varies a lot, but pretty low. Maybe around what an artist makes, slightly higher, but not much. Like, as much as the art guy?

A little bit more. A little bit, tiny bit. Eight.

Seven, eight. For...

[Speaker 1] (2:29:48 - 2:29:55)

Entry? For entry, less than eight. That's surprising, because this seems like the most critical part of the...

[Speaker 2] (2:29:55 - 2:30:02)

But that's because they don't have... Like, if you were a really good game designer, then sure, you could make a lot more.

[Speaker 4] (2:30:02 - 2:30:22)

And I have seen like creative director, who actually set the direction of the core gameplay, and even certain part of the outgame elements, they are maybe as equal as co-founder or founder, in terms of stock options or, you know, incentives they get from the success.

[Speaker 2] (2:30:22 - 2:30:28)

I mean, gaming's a creative field, so there's certainly potential for high payouts. Data analytics?

[Speaker 1] (2:30:31 - 2:30:32)

What does he do?

[Speaker 3] (2:30:33 - 2:30:38)

It's all about looking at the underlying data that is being generated by your game.

[Speaker 1] (2:30:39 - 2:30:40)

For example, what are the data points?

[Speaker 3] (2:30:41 - 2:31:29)

Retention is one of the biggest ones. For example, if 100 people played your game on the first day, when they downloaded the game, how many came back the next day? Now, once you know that 40 came back the next day, which is a good retention, generally, you lost 60.

Then you need to get into your game data and see what are the drop-off points. Where am I losing these users or these players, right? Are they launching the game and dropping off from the main menu of the game without playing anything?

Are they going into a certain level? Are they getting stuck there? And then dropping off.

So there's a lot of in-depth data that you need to get into to understand how you can improve the engagement of your game, right? I think no game can, unless it's just a hit by itself.

[Speaker 1] (2:31:30 - 2:31:36)

And how does somebody learn that? Inculcate that skill? I think it's...

[Speaker 3] (2:31:36 - 2:31:58)

Is it college? Of course, you need to have a very strong grip on numbers. How do you get that?

I'm assuming you're strong in maths, etc. There is also an aptitude to data and numbers. Yeah, it's good.

Basic aptitude and interest in data and numbers.

[Speaker 1] (2:31:58 - 2:32:00)

Where do you hire your data analytics guy?

[Speaker 3] (2:32:01 - 2:32:06)

I think we've hired them, at least for us. Many of them are from some of these good business

schools.

[Speaker 1] (2:32:07 - 2:32:10)

Business schools? And how much do you pay these people typically?

[Speaker 2] (2:32:12 - 2:32:16)

We just have our product managers do it, so we don't have a dedicated data analyst.

[Speaker 3] (2:32:16 - 2:32:29)

Yeah, I mean, we at least have a corporate team where we have a few people looking at data of a lot of our studios. Maybe 20-30 lakhs a year.

[Speaker 2] (2:32:31 - 2:32:33)

That's a lot. That's entry-level?

[Speaker 3] (2:32:34 - 2:32:38)

No, I mean, we don't have entry-level. At corporate, we have like six people looking at data.

[Speaker 1] (2:32:38 - 2:38:05)

I would assume it would be around 10, right? Now, I think the interesting question is to Animesh, what skill sets? I think I'll just give a few advices to how to be a gamer because there's no rule of thumb.

How can you be a gamer? First, I would say in India, first thing, backup. It needs to be mentioned that until you have reached that spot, it's always your backup thing that you are chasing.

It's a passion project. To become a gamer yourself is also a passion project. When do you transition from passion to full-time?

I would say your first contract where you're getting paid at least 35k a month. Rupees. Rupees is where you I can say that you are it's your profession here.

You're talking about gamer or content creator? Gamer. Content creator, I don't believe should ever chase money or contracts.

Build on your own. There is no rule of thumb. Even I cannot give any pieces of advice because so many factors, how good the person is, how creative they are, how fast they go viral, what clicks, what not.

But to a gamer. So start there. Second is your game type.

You know what sort of games you played. It's not always necessary to chase the hurdle, which is like going for battle royale games or a shooting game. Very fine example, Tirth Mehta who was also a part of my panel won an Asian Games medal way back in 2017, Hearthstone.

So that is another way. So you can always try to step out of the normal thing and find a different game. Third would be knowing the, knowing, so if in India you want to ensure that the publisher of that game is taking enough interest in India to build around that game.

For example, there is a game called Dota 2 for say. It does not have an active publisher interest in India. However, it's a very very big game outside as big as there is an event called The International whose price will go beyond $30 million for the main event.

But if the publisher is not interested then I would suggest don't opt for a game because then it would be very difficult for you to get into events or represent India at an international stage. Because you might be clubbed with the oceanic region or entire South Asia region or the sea region, which is difficult. Fourth would be if you are going for a team game, I would say it first, so everyone asks me how to build a team.

It's a very normal question if you are playing a team game. I think you cannot just go out and find other professional players who would want to build a team with you. You just start casually.

You get a few gamers, get to know people online and it's a process. The process could be finished in two months. You might not find a team in the next five years.

There is no rule of thumb again. It's just how social you are, how well you are aligned, how well you can talk to people. It's like you know those elements.

Your personality comes into play when you are finding a team. Skill comes at a later stage. Fourth would be once you are contracted, that's when the real hustle starts if you are ever contracted.

But I believe right now in India, Krafton with this grind that Krafton is doing, they have recognized 256 tier 1 and tier 2. Tier 1 means top teams of India. It's a very subjective thing.

Again, there is no benchmark of what a tier 1 team is. Then there are tier 2 teams who are trying to move into bigger events and qualify. So Krafton has right now identified 256 teams.

That means there are 256 good odd teams, which means 1250 odd players are, if not in a contract, they are doing something in gaming and they might have treated it as a profession. But I would say there are another thousand. So the number of teams are growing.

There are so many teams coming up in tier 2 cities. A businessman, a shop owner trying to build a team of his own. Maybe because his son insisted.

So those are things happening. So the point is people need to be aware about, a gamer needs to be aware of what's going on around him. Don't just look at Thug or Immortal and try to be them directly.

It was not easy for everyone, for anyone. And then I would say, when you get contracted, that's when you start doing your research. You have to just follow the correct way to move up the ladder.

Don't get complacent at where you are. That's what happens even in my team. I have, I guess in the last 6 years, contacted 80 players who have moved on to different teams.

Some have called it hang their boots. But I think I always want my players to keep moving on at a better stage. Even if not better, but at a parallel stage.

But I think it's a a gamer needs to keep moving places. Don't get stuck, especially in India. I'd love to come hang out with you guys once.

Yeah, you need to. Just for fun, right? Just for fun.

I think we covered like as much as we could. The last bit of every episode what we do is something for the community. In this case gaming.

So I ask each of you guys if you'd like to allocate money, time, something like that. And then we'll put out an open poll where we will filter and select maybe 20 people who show great potential in gaming. Like what you mentioned earlier.

Taking them to all the gaming companies in Bangalore for example. That would be great. Internships would be great.

Grants, small amounts of money to give them to pursue any of these paths at different stages would be great. Nitish, you want to start off? You want to like allocate or money or time or anything like that to help the gaming industry?

[Speaker 3] (2:38:05 - 2:38:08)

Absolutely. I mean as India's only listed gaming company.

[Speaker 1] (2:38:09 - 2:38:13)

Worth 5000 crores. 62-50.

[Speaker 3] (2:38:13 - 2:38:21)

62-50. That's the least we can do. And we are already doing a lot of that.

But yeah, very happy to allocate.

[Speaker 1] (2:38:21 - 2:38:25)

Do you want to say an amount and then we'll figure it out?

[Speaker 3] (2:38:25 - 2:38:31)

One crore to start with but we can double down on that.

[Speaker 1] (2:38:31 - 2:38:32)

Done.

[Speaker 2] (2:38:32 - 2:38:45)

Joseph, would you? I think I've already committed to doing that tour of some kind. So I'll do that and certainly I think not at this point until we're profitable but once we're profitable we absolutely intend on investing back into the community.

[Speaker 1] (2:38:45 - 2:39:40)

But you would be okay with say the 20 that we pick. Allocating maybe like 5 hours of time just in educating them. Some of them you might be able to hire.

Yeah. I would actually love to, you know 20 that short list I would love to mentor and actually know them why they are getting into it and then obviously with the consultancy I would like to then offer them the grant. I first need to, like the gamer within would always want to ensure that the person is in the correct, like wants to do something good.

Perfect. Yeah but I would love to give as much time. But you'll give them like proper time.

As much time. I'll go down to their city. No, we'll pick who it should be.

Who's the winner should be together. Like you guys come up with what metrics. We'll put this out.

Thousands of people will apply. We will try and find the most talented young minds in gaming available in India. Make a group of 20 and all of this for those 20.

100%. And the grant would come depending on the talent.

[Speaker 4] (2:39:40 - 2:39:40)

Done.

[Speaker 1] (2:39:40 - 2:39:40)

Sean?

[Speaker 4] (2:39:42 - 2:41:06)

I think somewhere in this conversation was briefly mentioned that we started incubator program. That is actually for quite professional level of developer who has actually made at least one or two games and they are capable of launching the game at the commercial level. I think you meant to help someone like before that.

I think for that we actually started to talking about how we expand the program to cover wider range especially for younger folks. I think we can maybe consider to combine this. Anyway, we had the idea of expanding the incubator program for wider teams.

Maybe the original incubator meant to get like 2, 3, 4 team per batch. Maybe 6 to 8 per year. I think that sounds larger than that.

I think that's they can fall into that extended program. We can offer mentorship. We can offer certain like short duration of teaching course and also we have certain partners on the cloud side and they can offer also credits.

Credits for cloud. So we have that sort of program. Perfect.

[Speaker 1] (2:41:07 - 2:41:46)

So I'll do one quote as well. So we will pick these 20 people and do all we can from time, money, grant, cloud, credits, mentorship. The only key here is I will lean upon you guys to pick who the 20 should be because I will get the applications in.

But maybe you guys can come together and figure out who the rightful 20 are because we'll do so much for them. Yeah. Sounds interesting.

Super. So thank you all for coming. This has been fun.

I've learnt a lot and I hope some people watching this will find this really useful. Thank you.

[Speaker 4] (2:41:46 - 2:41:47)

Thank you.

[Speaker 2] (2:41:48 - 2:42:09)

Hi everybody. I'm here with Be Famous, Nikhil. We just recorded a podcast WTF is and looking forward to seeing whenever it gets published.

How'd we do? We did well. Very well.

Okay. Hopefully it wasn't too bad.